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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

PRESIDENT FOR EFFECTIVE EXECUTION OF NATIONAL SECURITY POLICY

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 12

Prime Minister and National Security Council Chairman Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has submitted the annual report of the National Security Council to President Ramchandra Paudel.

After receiving the report at his office in Maharajgunj on Monday, President Paudel said that he was confident that the National Security Council would always be vigilant and determined to complete the works of the country's nationality, sovereignty, independence, integrity and national security.

PM SUBMITS NSC'S REPORT

A well-maintained and implemented national security policy of the country would be for developing cooperation between federal units by maintaining mutual harmony, tolerance and solidarity among different races, religions, sexes, languages and cultures.

President Paudel clarified that it was necessary to implement the national security policy effectively to ensure the security of all human beings by promoting national unity and safeguarding the freedom, sovereignty, geographical integrity and independence of the country.

He also said that a well-maintained and implemented national security policy of the country would be for developing cooperation between federal units by maintaining mutual harmony, tolerance and solidarity among different races, religions, sexes, languages and cultures.

President Paudel expressed his happiness that the National Security Council, which is established in accordance with Article 266 of the Constitution of Nepal, has presented concrete suggestions with its strategic approaches on the sensitive works of the country's nationality, sovereignty, independence, integrity and security.

Article 266 of the Constitution stipulates that the National Security Council must submit its annual report of its activities to the President annually.

Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Defence Purna Bahadur Khadka, Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Home Affairs Narayan Kaji Shrestha, Minister for Finance Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat and other members of the Council were present at the report submitting ceremony.



PHOTO COURTESY: PRESIDENT'S OFFICE
Prime Minister and Chairman of National Security Council Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' presenting annual report of the Council to President Ramchandra Paudel at Sheetal Niwas, Kathmandu on Monday.

Half-yearly budget review

Govt reduces budget size by Rs. 221 billion

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 12



Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat

The government has revised the budget for the current fiscal year 2023/24 by reducing the revenue and expenditure estimates.

The Ministry of Finance, in its half-yearly review of the budget, has reduced the size of the budget by about Rs. 221 billion to Rs. 1,530.26 billion for the current fiscal year. It is 87.38 per cent of the initially allocated budget.

The government had presented a budget of Rs. 1,751.31 billion for the current fiscal year on May 29, 2023.

Speaking at a press conference at the Ministry of Finance on Monday, Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat said that the government reduced the estimation of income and expenditure for the current fiscal year by analysing the half-yearly progress of both income and expenditure.

He said that the estimate was revised so that 88.84 per cent (Rs. 107.45 billion) would be spent on the heading of recurrent expenditure, 84.13 per cent (Rs. 254.13 billion) on the capital expenditure and 87.39 per cent (Rs. 268.67 billion) on the financial arrangement of the initial allocation.

By the end of the current fiscal year, it is estimated that around Rs. 1,309.30 billion will be arranged from government sources (revenue and domestic borrowing) Rs. 40.12 billion from foreign grants and Rs. 180.83 billion from foreign loans.

The government had set a target of raising Rs. 1,240 billion from revenue, Rs. 49.94 billion from foreign grants, Rs. 212 billion from foreign loans and Rs. 240 billion from domestic borrowing.

Dr. Mahat said that while trying to improve, the government had to reduce the expenditure estimate because the income could not increase as per the target. Although the steps taken by the government to improve the economy are gradually showing results, it is not possible to improve the economy all at once, Finance Minister Dr. Mahat said at the press meet.

He said that there would be no immediate results on economic reform, the matter of economic reform was not as easy as talked about. But, now the economy is on the path of improving trend," he said. It will continue to be improved in the coming days, he said.

He said that the state of low revenue collection and weak budget expenditure was still present.

Although the capital expenditure has been slow so far, the government will work to increase the expenditure in the future, Dr. Mahat said.

"Although the capital expenditure is not encouraging yet, the pace of expenditure will increase now. Works of amending many rules and laws have progressed. The revenue has increased compared to last year, but it is a little less than the initial target," he said.

Dr. Mahat said that it was difficult for the government to manage the budget because the obligations announced in the previous budgets were huge.

SEE PAGE 6

Nepal's 20.27% population still under poverty line

BY LAXMAN KAFLE
Kathmandu, Feb. 12



PHOTO: TRN
Summary report of Nepal Living Standard Survey IV being made public in the capital on Monday.

Still, 20.27 per cent of the population in Nepal lives below the poverty line.

According to the Nepal Living Standards Survey IV 2022-23 made public on Monday, of the people living below the poverty line, the majority are from rural areas.

The reports found that poverty was higher in rural areas than in urban areas. While in rural areas, the prevalence of poverty is 24.66 per cent, it is 18.34 per cent in urban areas.

The National Statistics Office conducted the NLSS survey by spending a year with the technical support of the World Bank.

Vice-chairman of the National Planning Commission Dr. Min Bahadur Shrestha made public the summary of the reports during a function.

The improvements in household consumption, political and administrative changes, as well as the aspiration towards becoming a middle-income country require that Nepal raise the bar and introduce a new line of measuring poverty in 2022/23.

According to the 2022/23 official poverty line, an individual in Nepal is classified as poor if their annual per capita total consumption expenditure is less than Rs. 72,908.

Highest poverty in Sudurpashchim Province

Presenting the findings of the survey, Dr. Hemraj Regmi, deputy chief statistician of the National Statistics Office, said that the NLSS-IV survey was the first living standards survey conducted in Nepal after the restructuring of the administrative and political boundaries since the promulgation of the constitution in 2015.

The survey contains information on a wide range of topics related to household welfare from a representative sample of 9,600 households from all 77 districts, except Manang.

There is considerable variation in the incidence of poverty across the seven provinces and the 15 administrative domains. The poverty rates are higher than the national rate in four provinces--- Madhes, Lumbini, Karnai and Sudurpashchim.

The poverty rate is highest in Sudurpashchim at 34.16 per cent, followed by Karnali at 26.69 per cent, Lumbini at 24.35 per cent and Madhes at 22.53 per cent.

SEE PAGE 6

Upper House okays University of Health Sciences Bill

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 12

Lawmakers emphasised the need for collaborative efforts to promote good governance and prosperity while speaking at the National Assembly meeting on Monday.

During discussions, lawmakers urged the government to address challenges such as corruption, prevent encroachment on government lands and enhance political transparency. They also called for increased efforts to generate employment opportunities within the country to discourage Nepali citizens from migrating abroad.

CPN-UML lawmaker Kumar Dasoudi proposed a programme to mount hope and confidence among the people, stating that prosperity should follow the political transition. He stressed the importance of identifying and addressing existing challenges and working towards increasing the hopes of citizens who have left the country due to disappointment.

Parliamentarian Nar Bahadur Bista acknowledged the government's efforts in streamlining public services amidst challenges. He urged the government to intensify its efforts to curb corruption, prevent land encroachment and enhance political transparency by realising the impact of corruption and poverty on government operations.

Minister for Law, Justice and Parliamentary Affairs Dhanraj Gurung said that he was not aware of corruption and those involved in such activities.

During a theoretical discussion on amending the laws related to money laundering prevention and the business environment, the parliamentarians criticised the government for suggesting provisions that might legitimise the wealth amassed through corrupt means.

SEE PAGE 6

630 pregnant and post-partum women rescued in six years

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 12

The government has provided free air rescue services to a total of 630 pregnant and post-partum women since the introduction of the President Women Upliftment Programme in 2018 to airlift the pregnant women if safe delivery was impossible in their locality.

According to figures released on Monday by the Ministry of Women, Children and Senior Citizens (MoWCSC), it rescued 78 women in the first six months of the current fiscal year.

The lives of 11 pregnant and post-partum women in remote areas were saved by airlifting in July/August last year. The lives of 14 women were saved in August/September month alone.

According to MoWCSC, 14 women were rescued in September/ October, 13 in October/ November, 10 in November/ December and 16 in December/ January month.

Most of the rescued women are from Bajhang, Bajura, Achham, Jajarkot, Khotang, Dhading, Sindhupalchowk, Gorkha, Kalikot, Dolakha, Solukhumbu, Okhaldhunga, Rukum (East and West), Dolpa, Dailekh, Humla, Jajarkot and Bhojpur.

From free air rescue service, the lives of 26 pregnant and post-partum women of remote areas were rescued in 2018/19, 87 in 2019/20, 103 in 2020/21, 169 in 2021/22 and167 in 2022/23 under the President's Women Upliftment Programme.

The government has been providing air ambulance service to the pregnant and postpartum women facing the risk of death for want of emergency medical service in line with the 'Procedure Related to Air Rescue of Pregnant and Post-partum Women of Critical Condition in Remote Areas-2018'.

SEE PAGE 6

Koshi Minister makes covert inspection of transport office

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Biratnagar, Feb. 12



Minister for Internal Affairs and Law Shumsher Rai of Koshi Province conducted a covert inspection at a trial centre of the Transport Management Office in Itahari, Sunsari, presenting himself as an ordinary citizen on Monday.

The inspection was carried out with the aim of finding misconduct and corruption activities at the trial centre.

Upon receiving numerous complaints related to dependency on brokers while receiving services at the transport office and corruption at the organisational level, Minister Rai reached the office as an ordinary client wearing an informal outfit.

According to Minister Rai, many weaknesses were witnessed during the inspection. He said, "Service seekers had to pay Rs. 500 for the eye test. Until bribing Rs. 500 one could not get their eyes checked. Additionally, the trial result, which needed to be recorded immediately after the trial in the field, was not documented."

He said that many people at the centre were found openly engaging in transactions with middlemen to get their licenses. Based on the transaction, settings were made accordingly at the Department of Transport Management, Koshi.

Minister Rai pointed out that the failure to document trial results immediately after conducting a trial indicated the presence of setting at a higher level. He said that although the transport offices were expanded to make the license services recipient-oriented, the dependency on middlemen still existed. He assured that steps would be taken to rectify misconduct at the transport offices.

Meanwhile, Chandra Prasad Prasai, the head of the Transport Management Office in Itahari, assured Minister Rai stating that they had prohibited middlemen on the premises. However, many middlemen were found present on the premises wearing masks and caps hiding their identities.

BULLION
(Rs. per tola)

Hallmark Gold	: Rs. 118,000
Worked Gold	: Rs. 117,450
Silver	: Rs. 1,395

STOCK

NEPSE	: 2,101.16
Total Amount	: 3,586,984,128.48
No. of Share	: 10,108,122

Murrah buffalo bull brought in Taplejung



PHOTO: CHANDRA PANDAK/TRN

Locals observing Murrah buffalo in Taplejung. Maiwakhola Rural Municipality had funded for the purchase of the bull of the Murrha buffalo.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Taplejung, Feb. 12

An advanced breed of Murrah buffalo bull has been brought to the Himalayan district of Taplejung. Maiwakhola Rural Municipality has brought the advanced breed of he-buffaloes for the first time in the district.

The advanced breed of Murrah buffalo bull has been brought to Dhungesanghu in Maiwakhola Rural Municipality-1.

According to Chandrakumar Tamang, the ward chairman of Maiwakhola Rural Municipality-1, the bull of the Murrha buffalo breed was brought with the funds allocated from the rural municipality for the current fiscal year and with the participation of local farmers.

Tamang said that one bull of the Murrah buffalo breed was purchased for Rs. 100,050, with cost sharing of 25 per cent of the farmers and the rest for the ward office. According to him, the Murrah buffalo was purchased from the Tarahara Buffalo Research Centre in Sunsari.

He informed that the improved breed of the Murrah buffalo bull was handed over to Dinesh Banem, the owner of the Sanjha-Bihani agriculture and animal husbandry firm located in Dhungesanghu on Sunday.

Ward Chairman Tamang said that they brought in the advanced breed Murrah buffalo to improve the breeding of buffaloes raised by the farmers as well as increase their milk production, and uplift the livelihood of farmers.

He said that with the bringing of the Murrah bull to the village, the local farmers would be more inspired towards animal husbandry business.

Farmers expressed their hope that due to the breeding of buffaloes with the advanced breeds, milk production would increase and they would get good income from animal husbandry. Earlier, India had decided to give 15 advanced breeds of Murrah buffalo bulls as a gift to Nepal.

JEFF BEZOS SELLS NEARLY 12 MILLION AMAZON SHARES

AP
Seattle, Feb. 12

Jeff Bezos filed a statement with federal regulators indicating his sale of nearly 12 million shares of Amazon stock worth more than $2 billion.

The Amazon executive chairman notified the U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission of the sale of 11,997,698 shares of common stock on Feb. 7 and Feb. 8.

The collective value of the shares of Amazon, which is based in Seattle where he founded the company in a garage about three decades ago, was more than $2.04 billion, according to the listed price totals.

The stocks were grouped in five blocks between 1 million and more than 3.2 million. In a separate SEC filing, Bezos listed the proposed sale of 50 million Amazon shares around Feb. 7 with an estimated market value of $8.4 billion.

Bezos stepped down as Amazon's CEO in 2021 to spend more time on his other projects, including the rocket company, Blue Origin, and his philanthropy. His address on the stock filings is listed as Seattle, although he reportedly has relocated to Miami.

FIRE BREAKS OUT AT A WATER PARK IN SWEDEN

AP
Copenhagen, Denmark, Feb. 12

A fire broke out Monday at a waterpark under construction at one of the Nordic region's biggest amusement parks, sending a huge plume of black smoke drifting over Goteberg, Sweden's second-largest city.

The blaze spread across several yet-to-be-opened waterslides at Liseberg park, and police and fire officials could not immediately say whether there were any casualties.

The fire department urged people in the area affected by the smoke to "go indoors and close doors, windows and ventilation" and listen to the local radio.

A nearby hotel and office facilities were evacuated, the park and police said. An explosion sent debris from buildings scattered over the burning waterslides.

"We have no information that there should be any injuries. We are now in the process of ensuring that this is the case," the head of communications at Liseberg, Mårten Westlund, told the daily Aftonbladet.

The fire broke out at the Oceana water park, which had been scheduled to open this summer. Swedish news agency TT said it cost 1.2 billion kronor ($10.6 million) to build. Westlund said the fire started in the part of the complex with four large slides.

Liseberg, in downtown Goteborg, is a popular tourist destination in Sweden. The idea behind Oceana was inspired by the history of Goteborg, founded in 1621 by King Gustav II Adolf. The city became an important trade place for Sweden.

Once completed, Oceana was to include an indoor swimming area of almost 6,000 square meters (7,176 square yards) and a 4,000-square-meter (4,780-square yards) outdoor swimming facility. Plans also call for a restaurant and a hotel. The park said up to 1,750 guests can visit the park at a time.

Cocoa price proves to be a headache for Hershey

AP
Washington DC, Feb.12

Hershey is cautioning on its 2024 profit growth as the company contends with rising cocoa costs that are leading to higher prices for chocolate.

Cocoa futures prices have doubled over the past year and hit an all-time high of $5,874 per metric ton on Friday. Bad weather in West Africa is being blamed for damaging crop yields, which is pushing cocoa prices higher.

"The magnitude and pace of recent price increases seem to be unprecedented," wrote Citi analyst Thomas Palmer.

With less than a week to go until Valentine's Day, chocolate is on the minds of many consumers. But with inflation concerns still top of mind, many shoppers are pulling back on their spending and eyeing rising food prices cautiously.



FILE PHOTO AP

Still, Hershey CEO Michele Buck is trying to ease consumers' minds. "Given where cocoa prices are, we will be using every tool in our toolbox, including pricing, as a way to manage the business," Buck said during the company's quarterly earnings conference call.

Hershey Co. anticipates its full-year earnings per share being relatively flat, partly due to higher cocoa and sugar costs. Margins may also face some pressure.

"The confection business is going to bear the brunt of the margin impact due to cocoa," Chief Financial Officer Steven Voskuil said on the call. Hershey's stock ended Friday down 3.4%.

Political tensions pose threat to US economy

AP
Washington, Feb. 12

Just a quarter of business economists and analysts expect the United States to fall into recession this year. And any downturn would likely result from an external shock — such as a conflict involving China — rather than from domestic economic factors such as higher interest rates.

But respondents to a National Association of Business Economics survey released Monday still expect year-over-year inflation to exceed 2.5% — above the Federal Reserve's 2% target — through 2024.

A year ago, most forecasters expected the U.S. economy — the world's largest — to slide into a recession as the Fed raised interest rates to fight a burst of inflation that began in 2021. The Fed hiked its benchmark rate 11 times from March 2022 to July 2023, taking it to the highest level in more than two decades.

Inflation has fallen from a peak of 9.1% in June 2022 to 3.4% in December. But the economy unexpectedly kept growing and employers kept hiring and resisting layoffs despite higher borrowing costs.

The combination of tumbling inflation and resilient growth has raised hopes — reflected in the NABE survey — that the Fed can achieve a so-called soft landing: vanquishing inflation without the pain of a recession.

"Panelists are more optimistic about the outlook for the domestic economy," said Sam Khater, chief economist at mortgage giant Freddie Mac and chair of the association's economic policy survey committee.

The Fed has stopped raising rates and has signaled that it expects to reduce rates three times this year.

But a growing share of business forecasters worry that the Fed is keeping rates unnecessarily high: 21% in the NABE survey called the Fed's policy "too restrictive," up from the 14% who expressed that view in August. Still, 70% say the Fed has it "about right."

What worries respondents are the chances of a conflict between China and Taiwan even if it isn't an outright war: 63% consider such an outcome at least a "moderate probability." Likewise, 97% see at least a moderate chance that conflict in the Middle East will drive oil prices above $90 a barrel (from around $77 now) and disrupt global shipping.

Another 85% are worried about political instability in the United States before or after the Nov. 5 presidential election.

The respondents are also increasingly concerned about U.S. government finances: 57% say budget policies — which have created a huge gap between what the government spends and what it collects in taxes — need to be more disciplined, up from 54% in August.

They say the most important objectives of government budget policy should be promoting medium- to long-term growth (cited by 45% of respondents) and reducing the federal deficit and debts (42%). Coming in a distant third — and cited by 7% — is the goal of reducing income inequality.

World Social Forum from Thursday

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 12

The World Social Forum (WSF) 2024 is set to take place in Kathmandu, Nepal, from February 15 to 19, 2024. WSF will be held at Bhrikutimandap under the theme "Another World is Possible."

The gathering, known for fostering dialogue among civil society organisations and social movements, will address pressing global issues like economic inequality, climate justice, labour rights and gender equality.

Originating from the Global South, the WSF emerged as an alternative to the World Economic Forum, growing from a small meeting in 2001 to a significant global event.

With 1,188 organisations from 91 countries participating, the forum promises a hybrid format, welcoming both in-person and virtual attendees. It will feature thematic panels, workshops, cultural events, and networking opportunities.

Key topics of discussion include climate justice, economic inequality, gender equality, labour rights, peace and indigenous peoples' rights, said Geeta Pandey, Director-Policy Advocacy and Research at Karnali Integrated Rural Development and Research Centre (KIRDARC) Nepal, the organiser.

According to Pandey, the people of the planet are currently facing an unprecedented climate crisis coupled with multiple crises. "As part of this momentous gathering, we are organising two significant events: Global Discourse: Navigating the Path to Climate Justice on February 16 and the Global Climate Justice Assembly, titled 'Mountain in Peril: Together for People and Planet' on February 17," she said.

These events aim to amplify the voices of affected communities and advocate for tangible measures to address the injustices perpetuated by climate change, she added.

The WSF 2024 aims to provide a platform for activists, organisations, academics, and individuals committed to social change to collaborate and strategise for a more equitable and sustainable future. Health and safety protocols will be implemented to ensure the well-being of all participants.

Guacamole getting harder on avocado shipments

AP
Mexico City, Feb. 12

Guacamole, a favored game-time snack in the United States, may be getting harder to make because a lack of rain and warmer temperatures have resulted in fewer avocados being shipped from Mexico.

The western state of Michoacan, which supplies almost 90% of the creamy textured fruit used in the Super Bowl snack, has suffered a hotter, drier climate that has led to a lack of water in growing areas.

Lakes in the state are drying up: Desperate avocado growers send tanker trucks down to suck up the last water, or divert streams, to feed their thirsty orchards, sparking conflicts. The state received about half the rain it normally gets last year, and reservoirs are at about 40% of capacity, with no rain in sight for months.

Meanwhile, some growers are illegally cutting down pine forests that feed the water system to plant more avocados. To top it all off, a nother American obsession — tequila — is starting to cause problems too.

The whole situation is not good for avocados. Last year, avocado exports from Michoacan for the Super Bowl grew by 20% to 140,000 tons. This year, that number actually declined by 2,000 tons, despite increased planting; meaning fewer of the creamy textured fruit in U.S. produce departments. Alejandro Méndez, the state secretary of the environment, estimates 30% of avocado orchards in Michoacan are now water-stressed.

Something's got to give, and with consumers demanding more environmentally conscious produce, state officials are finally putting together a sustainable certification program.

The certification program would presumably result in growers improving their water use, enabling them to offer consumers both greener avocados and more of them.

Coming soon to a grocery store near you: fruit with a sticker saying something like "this avocado wasn't grown on deforested land," or "this avocado used water responsibly."

Officials are still working on a catchy slogan for the greener avocados. But given that it's coming from the same people who brought you years of Super Bowl ads about avocados from Mexico, a catchy slogan is highly likely.

"The idea is that there is going to be a certification sticker with a QR code that you can scan with your telephone, and that link will take you to a page with a satellite photo of the orchard ... and the forest associated with the orchard," said Méndez.



PHOTO: AP

Avocado ready to be shipped.

Because they use more water than pine forests, growers will have to contribute to a fund that ensures several acres of forest are preserved for each acre of orchard.

"So with that orchard, you can be assured the dollar you paid for this avocado is going to preserve this piece of forest," said Méndez, who estimates about 70% of the orchards in place before 2011 were planted on old farmland, not forests. But the remaining 30% give the rest a bad name, he complains.

Ex-British Gurkha soldier Rai to get high civilian order of UK



File Photo: TRN

Former British Gurkha soldier Subash Rai.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Dharan, Feb. 12

Former British Gurkha soldier Subash Rai, a resident of Dharan, will be honoured with the title of Member of the Order of the British Empire (MBE), the third highest civilian honour of the United Kingdom, for his outstanding contribution to the British government.

He is going to be honoured with a medal from King Charles III of England at Buckingham Palace in England. This is a prestigious title given only to special personalities in the UK.

Rai said that he was going to be honoured for his special contribution to the support and social work of the British government while he was in the British

Army and even after his retirement. Before this, personalities like English footballer David Beckham were honoured with this award.

Rai joined the British Army in 1996 at the age of 21 and retired in 2014 after serving the British government for 18 years. Rai is still helping former British Gurkha soldiers who are in trouble.

After retiring from work, he has been active in politics along with social work.

Currently, he is a Mahasamimti member of the Nepali Congress.

He said that the British Gurkha Brigade Band will perform at the Dharan 10K Run and at the Depot School for former British Gorkha soldiers.

The British Gurkha Brigade band performs only on special occasions in the Kingdom.

The band performed at the Dharan 10K Run last year as well.

National Daughter meet ends



Photo: TRN

The participants of the 6th National Daughter Conference- 2080, pose for photograph at Birendrangar in Surkhet, Monday.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Surkhet, Feb. 12

The 6th National Daughter Conference-2080, held in Birendrangar, Surkhet concluded on Monday.

The three-day conference was held to unite daughters and women's rights activists from Nepal's east to west.

Raj Kumar Sharma, Chief Minister of Karnali Province, inaugurated the Daughter Conference organised by Mainstream Women Service Centre on February 10.

The theme of this year's National Daughter Conference was 'Commitment to Meet Sustainable Development Goal 5', and women participated at all decision-making levels.

Women representatives from across the country attended the conference.

A 17-point Karnali Declaration was also unveiled by the conference held under the chairmanship of Najbul Khan, coordinator of the National Daughter Conference.

Coordinator Khan said that necessary advocacy and cooperation would be made to increase the continuity and effectiveness of the programmes and campaigns for women's empowerment including the 'Savings Account of Daughter, Security of Life' and 'Daughter-in-law Scholarship Programme' of the local governments of Karnali Province.

He drew the attention of the stakeholders to expedite the security and rehabilitation works of the Jajarkot earthquake.

The programme was attended by human rights activists, government officials, education experts and representatives of adolescent girls.

Jumla-Nepalgunj Scorpio service begins



Photo: Netra Shahi/TRN

Scorpio transport service from Jumla to Nepalgunj begins.

BY NETRA SHAHI
Jumla, Feb. 12

Jumla-Surkhet-Nepalgunj Scorpio transport service has begun.

One passenger has to pay Rs. 2,500 to reach Nepalgunj from Jumla while the differently-abled people enjoy a 50 per cent discount on the fare.

Passengers have been attracted to the service after they enjoy the facility at a reasonable price. Karnali Himchituwa Transport Pvt. Ltd. has begun the service.

The Scorpio can transport nine passengers at once. Similarly, Tila Karnali Transport Entrepreneur Association has also begun the Jumla-Kathmandu night bus transport service. The bus carries 32 passengers.

President of Karnali Himchituwa Transport, Jumla, Bindas Rawal said that they were providing the Scorpio service to Surkhet and Kalikot with 50 per cent discount on the fare to the differently-abled people.

According to Rawal, it costs Rs. 2,500 to travel from Jumla to Surkhet and Rs. 3,150 to Nepalgunj.

He said that 28 Scorpio vehicles were providing the service in Karnali area under the 'Visit Karnali' programme. According to Rawal, 50 per cent discount will be provided to only the disabled persons.

Nanda Raj Dhital, a disability rights activist, thanked Karnali Himchituwa Pvt. Ltd. for giving 50 per cent discount I fare to disabled people by the Scorpio vehicle. According to the National Census 2078, the population of Jumla is 118,349 and 2.4 per cent of them are differently able.

DEUBA CALLS NC CENTRAL COMMITTEE MEET FOR THURSDAY

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 12

Nepali Congress president and coordinator of the Nepali Congress Mahasamiti meeting main organising committee Sher Bahadur Deuba has formed the finance sub-committee and named its coordinator and members.

According to a statement issued by Krishna Prasad Paudel, Chief Secretary of the party's central office on Monday, Deuba has given the responsibility of coordinator of the sub-committee to NC Central Committee member Anil Kumar Rungata.

Central Committee members Umesh Shrestha and Mohan Acharya, NC Bagmati Province Committee president Indra Baniya and NC Sankhuwasabha president Deepak Khadka are named as members of the sub-committee.

Likewise, Deuba added six members to the Food Management sub-committee headed by Central Committee member Uday Shumsher Rana.

The added members are Mekhlal Shresta, Sudarshan Ghimire, Pragatiman Ranjit, Nishan Dhungel, Rishidev Fuyal and Samjhana Bhattarai.

The NC is holding its Mahasamiti meeting in Godavari of Lalitpur from February 19.

Meanwhile, NC president Deuba has called the central committee meeting for Thursday afternoon.

According to a statement issued by the party, the meeting relating to the upcoming Mahasamiti meeting will be held at the party's central office in Sanepa, Lalitpur at 1.00 pm on February 15.

Women receiving passports to fly overseas increasing in Doti

BY DILLI BAHADUR SINGH
Doti, Feb. 12

> Dhami, who was at the District Administrative Office in Doti to make her passport, is not alone in flying abroad in search of employment.

Rama Dhami of Badikedar Rural Municipality of Doti is now preparing to go abroad as a migrant worker.

Dhami, who was at the District Administrative Office in Doti to make her passport, is not alone in flying abroad in search of employment.

She said that her three friends had already reached Kathmandu with their passports to make further processes to go abroad.

Like Dhami, more women from Doti have, of late, flown overseas for work and studies.

Until a few years ago, the women of the rural areas of Doti used to find it difficult to go outside their houses for work and study.

But, in recent days, more and more women from rural areas are found flying overseas either as migrant workers or as students.

According to the data of the District Administrative Office, of 364 total passports issued in the fiscal year 2020/21, 44 were received by women.

Similarly, of 848 passports issued in the fiscal year 2021/22, 101 were issued in women's name, and in the fiscal year 2022/23, the number of women receiving passports from Doti increased to 252 when the DAO had issued 2,052 passports in total.

Likewise, in the first seven months of the current fiscal year, 162 women and 985 men have received passports.

Dirgha Raj Upadhaya, Assistant Chief District Officer of Doti, said that most of the women in the past used to apply for passports to go abroad for studies, but in recent years more women have been receiving passports to go overseas as migrant workers.

Upadhaya said, "The number of women passport holders women has been increasing nowadays compared to previous years, and most of them are making passports to go abroad for studies."

In recent times, it has been found that most parents of students who pass with good marks tend to send their wards abroad for higher education.

Ramesh Karki of Shikhar Municipality of Doti hinted that his daughter was also making preparations to go abroad by saying that he was unable to tell his daughter not to go abroad when the daughters of his neighbours were making good progress abroad.

Prakash Madai, Co-Director of Needs Nepal, an organisation which has been running programmes on migration in Doti, said that like men more women were flying abroad for study and employment.

In the past, the youth from Doti used to go to India in search of jobs. Now when they have started flying overseas, many villages in Doti have been without youth.

CIAA Nepalgunj office receives 402 complaints

BY SIRAJ KHAN
Nepalgunj, Feb. 12

Office of Commission for the Investigation of Abuse of Authority (CIAA) Butwal, Liaison office, Nepalgunj received 402 complaints in four districts under its jurisdiction in the first seven months of the current fiscal year.

In a programme organised on the occasion of the 33rd establishment day of the CIAA in Nepalgunj office, Ganesh Bahadur Adhikari, head of the office, said that they received 402 complaints from Rolpa, Dang, Banke and Bardiya in the current fiscal year.

> Liaison office Nepalgunj head Adhikari informed that the majority of the cases (248) were against the local levels.

Additionally, 314 cases were transferred from the previous fiscal year.

Out of a total of 716 cases, 299 cases have been dismissed, he added.

According to the CIAA liaison office Nepalgunj, the highest number of complaints was received from Banke at 143 followed by Dang at 141.

Similarly, 60 complaints were received from Bardiya and 58 from Rolpa.

Of them, 143 cases are pending in Dang, 139 in Banke, 76 in Rolpa and 69 in Bardiya.

Liaison office Nepalgunj head Adhikari informed that the majority of the cases (248) were against the local levels.

He said that the office was crowded with cases as many cases could not be resolved by the end of the fiscal year and were carried over to the next fiscal year.

During the event, the Chief District Officer of Banke, Shravan Kumar Pokharel, described the overall situation of the district, emphasising the need for all offices, including the municipalities and district offices, to be serious about maintaining good governance and eliminating corruption.

On the occasion, Nepalgunj Sub-metropolitan City Mayor Prashant Bista, Federation of Nepali Journalist Banke chairman Damodar Bhandari and others said that everyone should be aware because corruption was taking place not only at the higher levels but also in smaller units.

Banke District Coordination Committee head Gyanendra Chaudhary said that the CIAA was doing an excellent job in controlling corruption and pointed out that everyone's support was needed for it.

Nepal Airlines

NEPAL AIRLINES CORPORATION
CONTINUING AIRWORTHINESS MANAGEMENT DEPARTMENT
Tribhuvan International Airport, Kathmandu, Nepal

Notice of Invitation for Sealed Tender
for NAC's A330-200 Base Maintenance Support Service

(International Competitive Bidding)
Date of First Publication 13th February 2024

Nepal Airlines Corporation (NAC), Continuing Airworthiness Management Department Invites Sealed Tender from Maintenance and Repair/Overhaul Organization (MRO) for base maintenance support services of its A330-200 aircraft fitted with RR Trent 772B engines. Sealed Tender must reach at the Office of the Continuing Airworthiness Management Department, Nepal Airlines Corporation, Tribhuvan International Airport, Kathmandu, Nepal in the office hours within Forty-Five (45) days from the date of first publication of this notice. The Maintenance and Repair/Overhaul Organizations (MROs) are encouraged to visit the Notice/Announcement page in NAC website: www.nepalairlines.com.np for detail information and downloading the Sealed Tender Document.

For further information, please contact:

Nepal Airlines Corporation
Continuing Airworthiness Management Department
Tribhuvan International Airport, Kathmandu, Nepal
Tel: +977 1 4113085 / 4113209, Fax: +977 1 4470768
Email: dir.camd@nac.com.np, dydir.epd@nac.com.np
Website : https://www.nepalairlines.com.np/notices

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

Common sense is the collection of prejudices acquired by age eighteen.
-- Albert Einstein

EDITORIAL

Record Temperatures

This past year, 2023, has been confirmed to be Earth's hottest year on record globally. First, June was the planet's warmest June on record. Then, July was the warmest July. The trend continued to December. For Nepal, it was the second hottest year since 1981, according to the Department of Hydrology and Meteorology (DHM), which has been keeping records since 1962. The average maximum temperature for the country in 2023 was 27.9° C, an increase of 0.6° C compared to the previous normal annual maximum temperature. The meteorological data underscores the complex climate patterns observed in Nepal, with variations in precipitation and temperature levels across different regions, alongside significant instances of extreme weather events like heat wave.

The recent worldwide findings have also shown that global warming has exceeded by 1.5° C since the dawn of industrial revolution, with January of this year being the warmest January on record. Scientists have warned for decades that warming needs to stay below the limit of 1.5° C. In 2015, world leaders pledged to try and prevent global temperature rise by more than this limit in what is known as Paris Climate Agreement, when, for the first time, almost all of the world's nations agreed to cut the greenhouse gas emissions. But if we take a cue from this report, it seems that window for meeting the climate goal is getting narrower, and we're running out of way to adapt to the climate crisis.

It's clear that unabated emissions of greenhouse gases pushed global warming to new highs. Warming climate intensifies heat waves and storms, melts glacier and ice blocks and increases sea level, displacing and risking settlements in coastal cities in every continent. These effects were unmistakably palpable last year: Heat wave baked countries from the US to Europe to China. Canada experienced its most devastating wildfire season on record. The sea ice formed in Antarctica coasts was less than at any point before. In Nepal, schools in Tarai had to be closed amid oppressive heat wave.

Extreme climate events have continued into 2024. Only a few days ago Chile experienced its deadliest wildfires on record, killing scores of people and destroying a vast swath of the country's green cover, and turning countless homes and neighbourhood into ashes. Similarly, Australia is reeling from sweltering heat waves and raging wildfires, putting its biodiversity at breaking point and prompting its government to put millions of people under warning. As the world continues to experience off-the-chart temperatures, a sobering questions arises: Why hasn't our effort to limit the warming gone far enough?

This is happening notwithstanding the rise of electric vehicles (EV), coal-power plants being phased out in favour of renewable sources of energy like wind and solar and heavy carbon polluters scaling back their operations, among other climate-friendly developments. Is the developed world, which bears the most blame for this crisis, doing enough to make good on its climate pledge to wean itself off the fossil fuel it has been addicted to? One thing is clear, though: much more needs to be done. In light of this grim data, communities, businesses and individuals have no option but to ready themselves to build resilience for the future. This means equipping ourselves to navigate the impacts of climate change that are increasing in frequency and severity.

Curb Alcohol Abuse

PALLAV BHUSAL

In a world marked by fast-paced lifestyles and increasing stimulators, the delicate balance between alcohol, drugs, and mental health has become a concern. The interconnected nature of these elements necessitates a conversation that transcends stereotypes and embraces the complexity of human well-being.

Alcohol and drug abuse often intertwine with mental health challenges, creating a vicious cycle that can be challenging to break. As society grapples with these intertwined issues, it is crucial to approach the subject with empathy, understanding, and a commitment to de-stigmatising mental health struggles.

Firstly, addressing the root causes of alcohol and drug abuse requires acknowledging the role of mental health. Individuals grappling with anxiety, depression, or trauma may turn to substances as a coping mechanism. It becomes imperative to view substance abuse not merely as a behavioural problem but as a symptom of underlying mental health issues. By shifting the narrative, we can foster a more compassionate and effective approach to intervention and support.

Moreover, the societal stigma surrounding mental health exacerbates the challenges faced by those seeking help. The misconception that mental health struggles are a sign of weakness impedes individuals from seeking timely assistance. A comprehensive strategy to tackle alcohol and drug-related issues must include de-stigmatising mental health concerns, encouraging open conversations, and promoting a culture of acceptance.

Prevention plays a pivotal role in breaking the cycle of substance abuse and mental health deterioration. Educational programmes that emphasise the risks associated with excessive alcohol and drug consumption, coupled with mental health awareness campaigns, can empower individuals to make informed choices. Early intervention through school curricula and community initiatives can equip individuals with the tools to navigate life's challenges more resiliently.

Treatment and rehabilitation efforts should be integrated, addressing both substance abuse and mental health concurrently. Holistic programmes that combine medical, psychological, and social support can yield more sustainable outcomes. Additionally, fostering a sense of community and belonging is crucial in preventing relapses, as individuals often turn to substances as a means of escaping feelings of isolation.

Public policy must reflect the understanding that alcohol, drugs, and mental health are interconnected issues requiring a multi-faceted approach. Adequate funding for mental health services, substance abuse treatment centres, and research initiatives can help bridge the existing gaps in our support systems. Legislators play a crucial role in shaping policies that prioritise prevention, education, and access to affordable mental health care.

Community involvement is equally vital in promoting a supportive environment for individuals facing these challenges. Local initiatives, such as support groups and awareness campaigns, can foster a sense of belonging and reduce the isolation often experienced by those grappling with mental health issues and substance abuse.

In conclusion, the intricate relationship between alcohol, drugs, and mental health demands a comprehensive and compassionate response from individuals, communities, and policymakers alike. By fostering a culture of understanding, providing accessible mental health resources, and implementing evidence-based policies, we can break the cycle of stigma and create a society where everyone feels supported on their journey towards well-being. It is time to recognise the interconnectedness of these issues and work collaboratively towards a healthier and more empathetic future.

Growing Corruption Plagues Nation

Narayan Upadhyay



Government land fraud and other sorts of corruption have continued to plague our country. Recently, three scams involving government land have made headlines. These land scam incidents have also been raised by several parliamentarians during the current session of Parliament, highlighting the issue of corruption and nefarious nexus prevalent in the government organisations. Scams including the Giri Bandhu Tea Estate in Jhapa, Bansbari Shoe Factory in Kathmandu, and Ram Gram Land in West Nawalparasi have hit the headlines. All these government land scams were perpetrated with the intention of causing financial losses to the government, while the same transactions benefited individuals, high-ranking bureaucrats, and politicians involved in decision-making.

The perpetrators are believed to have earned billions of rupees in a deal involving the tea estate in Jhapa, where land was transferred to numerous persons when the government chose to swap the pricey land with other government land to allow tea plantings. Even though the tea estate is government land and that individuals are not permitted to own any government land, the leaseholders began selling the estate land to others after the KP Sharma Oli-led government made a cabinet decision to swap the tea estate land for inexpensive land elsewhere in Jhapa district. The Supreme Court intervened and overturned the cabinet decision, preventing the leaseholders from selling the government assets because it violated existing legislation in the country.

Land transfer

Similarly, the board of directors of the Bansbari Shoe Factory in the past had transferred expensive government land to a business operated by a businessman, Arun Chaudhary, the brother of Nepal's only dollar billionaire, Binod Chaudhary, who later developed the land into a commercial housing area where he also runs a school. Despite the National Investigation Bureau apprehending Chaudhary and others implicated in the scam, the district court released the culprits on bail.

Meanwhile, the Lumbini Development Trust, led by newly appointed but controversial figure Lhyarkal Lama, agreed to sell Ram Gram Stupa land to a private corporation on a 99-year lease, apparently for a low sum. After the agreement made news, a parliamentary committee investigating the matter advised the government to cancel it because it would result in significant losses for the government while benefiting the private leaseholder. It is also stated that individuals engaged in granting the lease will benefit from the agreement.

The preceding three frauds have demonstrated that anytime government land is involved, persons ranging from entrepreneurs to low-ranking government officers to top-ranking bureaucrats, as well as leaders of all hues and stripes, are heavily involved. Corruption through opaque government land isn't our country's only significant issue. When acquisitions for building government projects are involved, significant names come up in connection with their anomalies as well as inappropriate deals aimed at causing losses to the government while benefiting individuals.

The CIAA recently interviewed two leaders, one a sitting minister and the other a former minister, for their involvement in the purchase of Teramax equipment by Nepal Telecom. Some telecom officials resigned after facing legal action because of the purchase of the Teramax for an excessively large cost by disregarding government-set public procurement guidelines. Previously, telecom officials and government secretaries faced public and anti-corruption criticism for reportedly buying telecom gateway technology at exorbitant costs without following the procurement process.

> Given the widespread nature of the corruption problem, only one institution's efforts will not suffice to combat corruption and bring perpetrators to justice.

Our only international airport is often in news for all wrong reasons. Huge amounts of gold are smuggled out, while persons travelling with an extra cell phone are apprehended and fined. A few days ago, the international airport became the scene of an undesirable incident: CCTV footage that went viral captured a confrontation between police officers and an immigration officer. It is reported that both police and immigration personnel at the airport have grudges against one another over the issue of human trafficking in the form of sending people on visit visas. Recently, authorities arrested numerous immigration agents stationed at the TIA for their involvement in transferring Nepali citizens abroad on visit visas. The issue arose after numerous Nepalis who operated as mercenaries in the Russian Army were killed during Russia's war with Ukraine.

It is often alleged that no government-related paperwork for citizens move ahead without paying bribes to officials. In the case of visit-visa, it was alleged that most of immigration officers deployed at the airport would receive bribes for allowing Nepali citizens to fly abroad under visit-visas. These unsavoury episodes tell us that everyone involved was out to make a lot of money through their shady connections with bureaucrats, top secretaries, ministers, and politicians. Corruption is thus a systemic problem in Nepal, firmly ingrained in its political, social, and economic structures.

There are various reasons for the growing threat of corruption, which is carried out through embezzlement of public assets, bribery, and nepotism. Nepal's political landscape has been characterised by instability and frequent government changes, providing fertile ground for corrupt practices to thrive. One of the most significant obstacles in eliminating corruption here is the development of a culture of impunity, which allows influential individuals and elites to avoid punishment for their acts. Weak institutional frameworks and poor enforcement mechanisms worsen the problem by allowing corrupt behaviours to go undetected. Furthermore, the close nexus between politicians and corporate interests frequently leads to cooperation and favouritism.

Anti-corruption initiatives

Although the current and past governments have often stated they have adopted several anti-corruption initiatives intended at encouraging openness, accountability, and good governance, they have not yielded the expected results so far. Political interferences, resource restrictions, and a lack of capacity in investigative organisations make the positive outcome quite difficult. Given the widespread nature of the corruption problem, only one institution's efforts will not suffice to combat corruption and bring perpetrators to justice.

Besides government efforts, civil society organisations, media outlets, and grassroots movements play critical roles in raising awareness about corruption and holding public officials and others accountable. Strengthening legal and regulatory frameworks, increasing the capacity and independence of anti-corruption organisations, promoting openness and rights to information, and cultivating a culture of integrity and ethical teaching can all contribute to better results in the fight against corruption.

(Upadhyay is former managing editor of this daily)

Take Action Against Erring Contractors

Uttam Maharjan



Development works are needed everywhere – be it in developed countries or developing countries. Every country needs infrastructure development or improvement. In Nepal also, development works are going on. They are a continuous process. Development works include not only new works but also maintenance works. For this, such works are often contracted out. There are many contractors working in the field of construction works in Nepal. But the performance of the majority of contractors is not satisfactory.

Delay in completing development projects has been the order of the day. The government is forced to extend the time of completion of projects not only once but several times. Still, some projects remain incomplete or are never completed. There are several implications of project delays. The people whom the benefits of development projects are targeted at are deprived of such benefits, sometimes affecting their life. Acquisition of vast swathes of land belonging to the people for hydropower projects is a case in point. In some cases, such victims get neither their land nor compensation for their land. In other words, they are bogged down in the quagmire of anger and frustration.

Proper contract

Construction works are ready to start after a proper contract between a contractor and the government is inked. For this, the contractor gets a certain amount of money. Some contractors tend to misuse such an amount, called mobilisation money, without initiating the work as per the contracts awarded to them. The contractors are often in cahoots with political parties or leaders. Their hobnobbing with such political parties or figures provides them with a kind of cushion. In fact, they are emboldened to do whatever they like instead of the following the contract provisions. Not only contractors but also businessmen have a close nexus with the political parties or leaders. The contractors and businessmen get political protection for financing the political parties or leaders during elections and at other times.

Worse, when the contractors become lawmakers, they may misuse their influence or powers to bend the relevant laws and policies in their favour. In the elections to the Federal Parliament and Provincial Assemblies held on November 20, 2022, several contractors were elected to the Federal Parliament and Provincial Assemblies. Some of them were Bikram Pandey (owner of Kalika Construction Private Limited), Mohan Acharya (owner of Rasuwa Construction), Purna Bahadur Tamang (owner of Kanchharam Construction Company Ltd.), Krishna Kumar Shrestha, Dhan Bahadur Budha Magar, Bahadur Singh Lama (owner of Himdung and Thokar Pvt. Ltd.) and Indra Bahadur Baniya (owner of Baniya Nirman Sewa).

It would be germane to mention that in 2018, the CIAA filed a corruption case against Bikram Pandey and 20 government officials and consultants on the charge of carrying out substandard works in the construction of the much-touted Sikta Irrigation Project. But all the accused were released by the Special Court. There is a trend among the contractors and businessmen of contesting elections. And some of them win the elections on the grounds of popularity or influence. After becoming members of parliament or even ministers, they can ensure better protection for themselves. Government officials cannot dare to take action against such contractors and others having political connections even if they do not complete the projects awarded to them. Rather, the government has to think twice before taking action against them!

> Worse, when the contractors become lawmakers, they may misuse their influence or powers to bend the relevant laws and policies in their favour.

Moreover, the lawmakers who are contractors can influence state decisions. In 2016, a bill on the Banks and Financial Institutions (BFIs) Act regulations were presented to the House of Representatives. The bill sought to bar those occupying constitutional posts from becoming the members of the BODs of BFIs. But a group of lawmakers from the business sector registered an amendment proposal, demanding that only chiefs and members of constitutional bodies be barred from joining the BODs of the BFIs. In the same year, some lawmakers owning private schools foiled the government's plan to convert all private schools into trusts through an amendment to the Education Act.

In a similar vein, in 2018, a number of contractors were nominated to the Development and Technology Committee of the House of Representatives. Fearing that they would influence the policy-level decisions in their favour, many other lawmakers openly protested. What is more, the contractors may influence amendment to public procurement regulations. There have been such instances for the past few years. When the contractors influence the acts, regulations and policies relating to contract works, what the quality of works will be or whether the projects will be completed in time is anybody's guess.

It is not possible to prevent the contractors from hobnobbing with the political parties or leaders, neither is it possible to bar them from contesting the elections. Both the contractors and political parties or leaders benefit from each other. But it is the general people who have to bear the brunt. Delaying projects not only troubles the people but also deprives them of the benefits the projects are supposed to provide them with. On the other hand, the political parties or leaders get financial benefits from the contractors, who are protected from any action the government may take against them for failing to abide by the provisions as encapsulated in the contracts.

Delay

The contractors, whether lawmakers or having political connections, should execute the contracts awarded to them. They should put the interest of the state above theirs. They should realise that they are part and parcel of development. They can play a pivotal role in accelerating development. They should make serious efforts to execute the tasks entrusted to them. They should not unnecessarily delay the projects on one pretext or the other for greed of increasing costs. They should encourage, not hinder, development works. They should be partners in development.

There are many irons in the fire when it comes to infrastructure development. First, the contractors should be honest. If they fail to fulfil their obligations under the contracts, the government should penalise them. Just revoking the contracts does not seem to be enough. Such erring contractors should be made to pay hefty fines as compensation. Also, their licences should be cancelled. The government should come down heavily on the erring contractors if it wants to see development projects completed in time. And the state of impunity the erring contractors have been enjoying for years under the aegis of political connections will definitely grind to a halt if the government takes harsh measures.

(Maharjan has been regularly writing on contemporary issues for this daily since 2000.)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

February 13, 1974

Free Health Camp

Kathmandu, Feb 12: A free health centre is to be opened at Dhorpatan of Dhaulagiri zone, it is learnt, says RSS.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

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READER'S MAIL

Ensure Justice To Conflict Victims

This refers to a news report '*Once consensus eludes on transitional justice, due process begins: Ramesh Lekhak*' published in the digital version of this daily on Sunday. According to the report, Nepali Congress lawmaker Ramesh Lekhak said that if consensus eluded among political parties on transitional justice, due process would be followed to conclude it.

In principle, Lekhak's view is not otherwise. But transitional justice (TJ) process is tricky and sensitive, requiring a consensus among all stakeholders concerned. The conflict victims are waiting for justice for their loved ones who were killed or disappear in the insurgency.

Justice delayed is justice denied, goes a saying. The TJ process has been inordinately protracted as the major parties in the parliament have been divided on the content of a Bill that seeks to amend the Investigation of Enforced Disappeared Persons, Truth and Reconciliation Commission Act



(2014). It was presented to parliament on March 19, 2023 but it has been pending in the absence of required agreement on it.

Rights activists insist that the victims would not get justice if the Bill was approved in its current forms, claiming that it did not comply with the domestic law and international standards. Now the ruling and opposition parties should work together in sorting out their differences so as to ensure transitional justice to the victims in earnest.

Roshan Rokaya
Jajarkot

TAILPIECE

One day, a blonde's neighbor goes over to her house, sees the blonde crying, and asks her what happened.

The blonde said that her mother had passed away.

The neighbor made her some coffee and calmed her down a little and then left.

The next day the neighbor went back over to the house and found the blonde crying again.

She asked her why she was crying this time.

The blonde said, "I just got off of the phone with my sister. Her mother died too!

Biden, King of Jordan to discuss framework for hostage deal

AP
Washington, Feb. 12

President Joe Biden is hosting Jordan's King Abdullah II in Washington Monday and the two leaders are expected to discuss the ongoing effort to free hostages held in Gaza, and growing concern over a possible Israeli military operation in the port city of Rafah.

It is the first meeting between the allies since three American troops were killed last month in a drone strike against a U.S. base in Jordan. Biden blamed Iran-backed militias for the fatalities, the first for the U.S. after months of strikes by such groups against American forces across the Middle East since the start of the Israel-Hamas war.

The meeting with King Abdullah II comes as Biden and his aides are working to broker another pause in Israel's war against Hamas in order to send humanitarian aid and supplies into the region and get hostages out. The White House faces growing criticism from Arab-Americans over the administration's continued support for Israel in the face of growing casualties in Gaza.

It appeared a deal for another pause in the fighting was getting close. A senior U.S. administration official said Sunday that after weeks of shuttle diplomacy and phone conversations, a framework was essentially in place for a deal that could see the release of the remaining hostages held by Hamas in Gaza in exchange for a halt to fighting.



PHOTO: AP

Jordan's King Abdullah II bin Al-Hussein attends a military ceremony in Vienna, Oct. 25, 2021. President Joe Biden is hosting Jordan's leader in Washington on Monday, Feb. 12, 2024.

The official, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss the negotiations, acknowledged that gaps remained but declined to specify what they are. The official said Israeli military pressure on Hamas in Khan Younis over the last several week s has helped bring the militant group closer to accepting an agreement. The potential for an agreement took up the majority of Biden's call Sunday with Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu.

The official said the two leaders also had a significant back and forth about the potential expansion of Israeli military operations into Rafah and that Biden reiterated U.S. opposition to the idea under the "current conditions" while more than 1.3 million people are sheltering there.

It was the most forceful language yet from the president on the possible operation. Biden, who last week called Israel's military response in Gaza "over the top," also sought "urgent and specific" steps to strengthen humanitarian aid. Israel's Channel 13 television said the conversation lasted 45 minutes.

The official said the Israelis "made clear they would not contemplate an operation" in Rafah without safeguarding the civilian population. The official said the U.S. is not sure there is a feasible or implementable plan to relocate civilians out of Rafah to allow military operations to take place.

Jordan and other Arab states have been highly critical of Israel's actions and have eschewed public support for long-term planning over what happens next, arguing that the fighting must end before such discussions can begin. They have been demanding a cease-fire since mid-October as civilian casualties began to skyrocket.

Biden had planned to visit Jordan during his trip to Israel in October shortly after the Oct. 7 attack by Hamas, but the trip was scrapped. On his way home from Israel, Biden announced he'd helped broker the first deal to pause fighting temporarily and to open the crossing in Rafah to humanitarian aid.

In the months since, members of his administration have made repeated trips to the region to engage with leaders there.

EGYPT THREATENING TO VOID TREATY WITH ISRAEL

AP
Jerusalem, Feb. 12

It was a warm handshake between the unlikeliest of statesmen, conducted under the beaming gaze of President Jimmy Carter. Sunlight streamed through the trees at Camp David, Maryland, as Egyptian President Anwar Sadat and Israeli Prime Minister Menachem Begin solidified a landmark agreement that has allowed over 40 years of peace between Israel and Egypt. It has served as an important source of stability in a volatile region.

That peace has held through two Palestinian uprisings and a series of wars between Israel and Hamas. But now, with Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu vowing to send Israeli troops into Rafah, a city in Gaza on the border with Egypt, the Egyptian government is threatening to void the agreement.

Here's a look at the history of the treaty and what could happen if it is nullified.

It was 1977, and Begin, Israel's new prime minister, opposed ceding any of the land Israel had conquered a decade earlier in the 1967 Mideast war. Those lands included Egypt's Sinai Peninsula.

Egypt and Israel had fought four major wars, most recently in 1973. So it shocked the world when Egypt's Sadat broke with other Arab leaders and decided to engage with the Israelis.

The talks culminated in the Camp David Accords in September 1978 and a peace treaty the following year.

Under the peace treaty, Israel agreed to withdraw from the Sinai, which Egypt would leave demilitarized. Israeli ships were granted passage through the Suez Canal, a key trade route. The countries established full diplomatic relations in Israel's first peace agreement with an Arab country.

Stubb wins Finnish presidential election

XINHUA
Helsinki, Feb. 12

The presidential candidate for the National Coalition Alexander Stubb narrowly won the Finnish presidential election Sunday night.

With all the votes counted, Stubb got 51.6 percent of support in the final round, while Independent Green candidate Pekka Haavisto obtained 48.4 per cent, according to figures released by the Finnish Ministry of Justice.

"I can promise that I will do my best every single day for this task," Stubb said after being confirmed Finland's next president.

Commenting to the media, Stubb said that Finland is now entering a new era. "I would like to continue along the lines of Niinisto, but it is understandable that a new era is starting," he said.

Stubb will be sworn in as the Nordic nation's 13th president on March 1, replacing Sauli Niinisto.

Sami Borg, an election analyst for national broadcaster Yle, said the result is the tightest in the era of a direct popular vote.

During the election evening, Haavisto's share kept increasing as the count progressed, but he was not able to catch up with the difference.

The voter turnout was 70.7 per cent, down from 75 percent in the initial round.

Stubb, 55, had worked as a member of the European Parliament, member of the Finnish parliament, Finnish prime minister, foreign minister, and deputy director general of the European Investment Bank. He holds a Ph.D. in international politics and speaks Swedish, Finnish, English, French, and German.

A presidential election is held in Finland every six years. The election is conducted through a direct popular vote. Nine candidates competed in the initial round on Jan. 28 this year, with the top two advancing to the final round.



PHOTO: XINHUA

Alexander Stubb speaks to the media in Helsinki, Finland, Feb. 11, 2024. The presidential candidate for the National Coalition Alexander Stubb narrowly won the Finnish presidential election Sunday night.

Khan supporters block highways to protest election results in Pakistan

AP
Quetta, Pakistan, Feb. 12

Thousands of supporters of Pakistan's imprisoned former Prime Minister Imran Khan and members of other political parties blocked key highways and started a day-long strike in the volatile southwest Monday to protest alleged rigging of last week's elections.

Candidates backed by Khan won more seats than the political parties who ousted him from power nearly two years ago, according to the final tally published Sunday. However, no party won a majority, so the parties will have to hold talks on forming a coalition government. The new parliament chooses the country's next prime minister.

Thursday's vote to choose a new parliament was overshadowed by the vote-rigging allegations, an unprecedented mobile phone shutdown, and the exclusion of Khan and his Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf party, or PTI, from the vote.

While election winners were celebrating victory, PTI and other parties refused to accept their defeat in dozens of constituencies. Dozens of Khan's supporters were briefly detained in the eastern city of Lahore over the weekend while protesting alleged vote-rigging.

Jan Achakzai, a government spokesman in the southwest province of Baluchistan, urged protesters to "show grace" by accepting defeat and moving away from the highways.

Khan could not run in the election because of the criminal convictions against him that he says are politically motivated.

Candidates aligned with Khan secured 101 out of 266 seats in the National Assembly, or lower house of parliament.

The Pakistan Muslim League-N party led by three-time premier and ex-felon Nawaz Sharif secured 75. Sharif is currently in talks with allies to form a coalition government.

The Pakistan People's Party, or PPP, led by Bilawal Bhutto-Zardari, came in third with 54 seats. One result has been withheld and another vote was postponed because of a candidate's death. The campaign to kick Khan out of office in 2022 was led by the PML-N and the PPP.

Pakistan's military has always cast itself as the ultimate arbiter of who becomes prime minister, and Sharif was marked out as the powerful security establishment's preferred candidate because of his smooth return to the country last October.

Sharif spent four years in exile to avoid serving prison sentences but his convictions were overturned within weeks of his arrival in Pakistan.



PHOTO: AP

Supporters of Pakistan's Former Prime Minister Imran Khan's party 'Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf' chant slogans during a protest, in Karachi, Pakistan, Feb. 12, 2024.

PRISM

Largest balloon assembled in HK

Hong Kong: A dragon sculpture made from approximately 38,000 balloons at a Hong Kong shopping mall was awarded a Guinness World Record.

Balloon artists Sze Tai "Wilson" Pang and Kun Lung Ho led more than 60 volunteers in constructing the sculpture.

The finished dragon measured 137.04 feet long, earning the Guinness World Record for the largest balloon sculpture of a dragon.

The sculpture was created as part of Chinese New Year celebrations and will remain in place until the end of February.

The artists said the biggest challenge was to make sure the dragon remained in one piece without any kind of non-balloon support structure.

Escaped kangaroo captured in Florida

Florida: An escaped kangaroo paid a visit to an apartment complex and ended up captured when deputies trapped it in the pool area.The Hillsborough County Sheriff's Office said deputies responded to a report of a kangaroo on the loose in an apartment complex near Fowler Avenue and 56th Street in Tampa.

Deputies were able to trap the kangaroo in the complex's fenced-in pool area.

The sheriff's office said the wayward marsupial was returned to its owner after the Agriculture Unit verified the proper registrations to keep the exotic animal were in place.

(Agencies)

One in five migratory species faces extinction

AFP
United Nations, Feb. 12

From African elephants searching for water, to turtles crossing seas to nest, and to albatrosses on their ocean-spanning search for food, the world's migratory species are under threat across the planet, according to a landmark report Monday.

The first-ever State of the World's Migratory Species assessment, which focusses on the 1,189 species covered by the UN Convention on the Conservation of Migratory Species of Wild Animals (CMS), found that one in five is threatened with extinction and 44 percent are seeing their populations decline.

Humans are to blame, by destroying or breaking up habitats, hunting, and polluting areas with plastics, chemicals, light and noise.

Climate change also threatens to interfere with migration routes and timings, by altering seasonal conditions.

"We are finding out the phenomenon of migration itself is under threat," CMS chief Amy Fraenkel told AFP, adding that the report should be a "wake up call about what's happening".



FILE PHOTO: AP

A researcher uses a clothes hanger to secure a geo-locator in place on the leg of a Red Knot shore bird while the glue dries on the north end of Nauset Beach in Eastham, Mass., Tuesday, Sept. 17, 2013. Nearly half of the world's migratory species are in decline, according to a new United Nations report released Monday, Feb. 12, 2024.

The report is released as over 130 signatory countries -- with the notable absence of the United States, China, Canada and Russia -- gather for a conference in Samarkand, Uzbekistan from February 12 to 17.

Migratory species often rely on much specialised sites to feed and mate and their journeys between them can cross international borders and even continents.

Iconic species that make some of the most extraordinary journeys across the planet include the monarch butterfly, the humpback whale and the loggerhead turtle.

"Today's report sets out the evidence that unsustainable human activities are jeopardising the future of migratory species," said Inger Andersen, head of the United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP).

Among the chief threats are agriculture and fishing.

Farming can destroy habitat, Fraenkel said, while "bycatch" by fishing vessels -- when other fish or animals become ensnared by fishing gear -- is the biggest continued threat for whales.

She said that while habitat destruction is considered the main risk to migratory animals, for some species the report found that it was "intentional killing", either for wild meat, or sport, or because the animals are thought of as pests.

"There is a big gap that we've now identified that needs action," she said.

The report, compiled by UNEP's World Conservation Monitoring Centre, found that over the past three decades, 70 CMS-listed species have become more endangered, including the steppe eagle, Egyptian vulture and the wild camel.

Just 14 now have an improved conservation status -- including blue and humpback whales and the white-tailed sea eagle.

Of the 158 mammals listed under the convention, 40 percent are globally threatened, according to the report.

Meanwhile almost all -- 97 per cent -- of the 58 fish species listed are facing a high risk of extinction, including migratory sharks, rays and sturgeons.

More than 960 species of birds are CMS-listed and while only 14 per cent were assessed as threatened, the authors stressed this still amounts to some 134 species.

The report also found 399 migratory species -- including albatrosses, ground sharks and stingrays -- are categorised as threatened or near-threatened but are not yet CMS-listed.

The report, which is intended to feed into the Samarkand conference, includes a focus on species most at risk, highlighting the threats from fishing, farming and pollution.

They echo a flagship biodiversity agreement in 2022, when countries agreed to preserve 30 percent of the planet's land and sea by 2030.

Many of the migratory species listed on CMS provide economic value or "services" useful to humans -- from tourism centred on whales, dolphins, elephants and cheetahs to the pollination provided by birds and bats.

TODAY IN HISTORY

962 – Emperor Otto I and Pope John XII co-sign the Diploma Ottonianum, recognizing John as ruler of Rome.
1258 – Siege of Baghdad: Hulegu Khan, a prince of the Mongol Empire, orders his army to sack and plunder the city of Baghdad, which they had just captured.
1322 – The central tower of Ely Cathedral falls on the night of 12th–13th.[3]
1542 – Catherine Howard, the fifth wife of Henry VIII of England, is executed for adultery.
1633 – Galileo Galilei arrives in Rome for his trial before the Inquisition.
1861 – Italian unification: The Siege of Gaeta ends with the capitulation of the defending fortress, effectively bringing an end of the Kingdom of the Two Sicilies.
1867 – Work begins on the covering of the Senne, burying Brussels's primary river and creating the modern central boulevards.
1880 – Thomas Edison observes Thermionic emission.



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

Chinese artistes presenting a show of dragon on the occasion of Chinese New Year at a programme organised in the capital on Monday.

People's War Day is a day of all Nepalis: PM Prachanda

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb. 13

The people's war adopted the dream of change dedicated to political, socio-economic, cultural, freedom, patriotism and nationalism.

Prime Minister and CPN (Maoist Centre) Chairperson, Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said rights and achievements established on the foundation of people's war are common assets of the nation.

In a message on the occasion of 29th People's War Day, Chairperson Prachanda shared that although the people's war was led by CPN (Maoist), it is the common day of all Nepalis who want identity, rights, freedom, liberation, justice and change-loving people.

Stating that the people's war adopted the dream of change dedicated to political, socio-economic, cultural, freedom, patriotism and nationalism, he mentioned that federal democratic republic was established in coordination of people's movement and on the foundation of people's war.

"Inclusive democracy is institutionalised on the foundation of people's war. Identity and rights of oppressed classes, castes, genders, regions, and communities including Madhesi, Muslim, Dalit, Indigenous, and Tharu communities have been established", reads the message.

Sharing that the CPN (Maoist Centre) is organising first statute convention on the 29th people's War Day, Chair Prachanda expressed the belief that party's internal affairs would be systematic and strong and contribute for building a capable party to lead socialist revolution.

He extended best wishes to all Nepalis in the country and abroad and change-loving communities in the world on the occasion of the People's War Day.

The CPN (Maoist Centre) Chairperson extended tribute to the martyrs, who sacrificed their lives for change, high-respect to missing warriors and wished the wounded and disabled warriors a long-life and good health.

Chair Prachanda appealed to all communities to observe this day as a national celebration and pride with different creative programmes.

Activists Iih begins Lumbini-Singha Durbar march

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Bhairahawa, Feb. 12

Activist Iih has embarked on a journey from Mayadevi Temple in Lumbini to Singha Durbar starting on Monday to make the government aware of the problems faced by the urban poor, street vendors and people associated with the informal sector. Iih is accompanied by another activist.

Activist Iih said that they started the journey to convey the Buddha's message of compassion to the government.

During the journey, the problems would be collected by holding discussions and interactions with the road vendors and people associated with the informal sector in both rural areas and urban centres, said Iih.

"We want to convey Buddha's message of compassion and sympathy to the Singha Durbar. The journey will continue for nine days," he said.

He reached Tilottama of Rupandehi from Mayadevi on Monday, the first day. He said he would reach Singha Durbar on February 19 via Sunwal of West Nawalparasi, Dumkibas of Nawalpur, Daldale, Ramnagar of Chitwan, Kurintar, Gajuri and Naubise of Dhading.

Campaigner Iih has put forward three main demands in this regard. He demanded that the government should issue directives to manage and bring programmes in favour of the urban poor, and request to amend the law for their long-term management.

"The disease of displacing the urban poor has become nationwide, therefore, it is necessary to raise the voice for the welfare of the poor in the society," said activist Iih.

Himal Upreti, an archaeological officer of Lumbini Development Trust, saw off the two activists.

Israeli forces rescue 2 hostages in dramatic Gaza raid

AP
Rafah, Feb. 12

Israeli forces rescued two hostages early Monday, storming a heavily guarded apartment in a densely packed town in the Gaza Strip and extracting them under fire and covering airstrikes that local officials said killed at least 67 Palestinians.

The plight of the dozens of hostages held by Hamas has profoundly shaken Israelis, and the rescue in Rafah briefly lifted the spirits of a nation still reeling from the militant group's cross-border raid last year that started the war. Israel has described Rafah — a city on the southern edge of the Gaza Strip where 1.4 million Palestinians have fled fighting elsewhere — as the last remaining Hamas stronghold in the territory and signaled that its ground offensive may soon target the city.

In Gaza, the operation unleashed another tragedy in a war that has killed more than 28,000 Palestinians in the territory, displaced over 80% of the population and set off a massive humanitarian crisis.

More than 12,300 Palestinian minors — children and young teens — have been killed in the conflict, the Health Ministry in Hamas-run Gaza said Monday. About 8,400 women were also among those killed. That means minors make up about 43% of the dead and women and minors together make up three quarters.

The ministry, which does not distinguish between combatants and civilians, provided the breakdown at the request of The Associated Press. Israel claims to have killed about 10,000 Hamas fighters. In Hamas' cross-border raid on Oct. 7, an estimated 1,200 people, mostly civilians, were killed, and militants took 250 people captive, according to Israeli authorities.

Israel says about 100 hostages remain in Hamas captivity after dozens were freed during a cease-fire in November. Hamas also holds the remains of roughly 30 others who were either killed on Oct. 7 or died in captivity.

The government has made freeing the hostages a top aim of its war, along with destroying Hamas' military and governing capabilities. But as the fighting drags on, rifts have emerged in Israel over how to retrieve them.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu says persistent military pressure will bring about the captives' freedom even as families of the hostages and many of their supporters have called on the government to make another deal with Hamas.

Israeli military spokesman Rear Adm. Daniel Hagari said special forces broke into a second-floor apartment in Rafah under fire at 1:49 a.m. Monday, accompanied a minute later by airstrikes on surrounding areas. He said Hamas militants were guarding the captives and that members of the rescue team shielded the hostages with their bodies as the battle erupted.

The army identified those rescued as Fernando Simon Marman, 60, and Louis Har, 70, who were abducted by Hamas militants from Kibbutz Nir Yitzhak on Oct. 7.

Govt...

The indicators of the economy are becoming positive, he said, adding that the economy has, however, not improved according to the target set by the government.

The revenue mobilisation which was negative last year has increased by 9 per cent this year, Dr. Mahat said.

"Liquidity has improved in the banking sector, interest rates are decreasing, the balance of payment has improved and the number of tourists visiting Nepal has increased."

The government had set a target of 6.5 per cent inflation in the current fiscal year.

According to the data published by the Nepal Rastra Bank, the average price inflation till mid-December was 6.47 per cent.

Minister Dr. Mahat said that the government would implement the projects which contribute to the long-term development and create jobs with due priority.

He said that the tendency to create additional economic liability without permission from the Ministry of Finance would completely be discouraged. The ministry aims to improve the land acquisition law to manage the compensation determination, and to make the forest law up-to-date to facilitate the use of the forest area, he said.

630 pregnant...

The procedure aims to provide quality and dependable service to such women living in remote areas where proper medical facilities required for patients are not available.

The MoWCSC said that the programme had been effective in protecting the citizens' constitutional right to safe motherhood and reproductive health.

This facility is available to women in 48 districts. Out of 48 districts, the facility is fully available in 19 districts and partially in 29 districts.

Upper House okays University...

Meanwhile, the Shaheed Dashrath Chand National University of Health Sciences Bill was unanimously passed by the National Assembly. Presented by Ashok Kumar Rai, Minister for Education, Science, and Technology, on October 6, 2023, the bill aims to advance research in health sciences to improve access to health services by locally producing health personnel.

Simultaneously, a resolution proposal was submitted to the National Assembly, advocating for the creation of 151 laws to facilitate the implementation of the constitution. CPN-UML lawmaker Dilkumari Rawal initiated the proposal, gaining support from eight other National Assembly members.

Pramila Kumari, State Minister for Education, Science, and Technology, affirmed that the Vice-Chancellor selection procedures at Tribhuvan University would adhere to the existing rules. During the session, she clarified that no complaints were lodged against any individual in the recommendation committee. State Minister Kumari assured that due process was followed, and the procedure was in compliance with the law.

Reconsider short-listed VC candidates: Committee

Meanwhile, the Education, Health, and Technology Committee in the House of Representatives urged the Ministry of Education, Science, and Technology and the Vice-Chancellor Recommendation Committee to reconsider the short-listed candidates for the position of Vice-Chancellor at Tribhuvan University. After holding discussions during the committee meeting, the decision was taken citing concerns about their involvement in intellectual theft, corruption, and concealing information.

Committee Chairman Bhanubhakta Joshi informed that the Ministry and the Recommendation Committee were urged to re-evaluate the raised issues. Joshi emphasised the need for special consideration for individuals facing accusations during the vice-chancellor selection process. Additionally, the committee called for an investigation into decisions made by the Acting Chancellor of Tribhuvan University and recommended necessary actions. Joshi appealed to make the Vice-Chancellor appointment process transparent so that people would not raise any questions.

Nepal's 20.27% population still...

However, the rate of poverty in Gandaki, Bagmati and Koshi Province is lower than the national rate at 11.88 per cent, 12.59 per cent and 17.19 per cent, respectively. The poverty depth and severity are also higher in provinces with higher poverty.

According to the report, the rural domains have higher poverty rates than urban areas in each province, except for Lumbini and Gandaki.

The report found that Nepal has a Poverty Gap index of 4.52 per cent, implying that a total of Rs. 94.71 billion is needed to bring the poor up to the minimum welfare threshold defined by the new poverty line 2022/23 assuming perfect targeting and zero leakage.

The average shortfall of mean income is higher in rural areas at 5.64 per cent compared to 4.03 per cent in urban areas.

Non-food expenditure increases

The survey found that the annual spatially and temporally adjusted per capita consumption expenditure has increased by 66 per cent in real terms between 2011 and 2023.

The average annual per capita consumption expenditure has increased to Rs. 126,172 in 2023 from Rs. 75,902 in 12 years. The share of non-food spending has increased from an average of 38 per cent to 47 per cent over the same period.

The report found that the average annual nominal per capita expenditures in the Kathmandu Valley are highest at Rs. 263,318 in 2022/23 prices.

Gandaki Urban has the second highest expenditure at Rs. 176,542 per year, which is 67 per cent of that in the Kathmandu Valley.

The lowest average annual nominal per capita expenditures are in Madhes rural and Sudurpashchim rural at Rs. 71,828 and Rs. 72,861 per person per year respectively.

The report showed that the average share of food spending is lower for individuals with a higher per capita consumption across the domains.

For the poorest 20 per cent of the population, food accounts for at least 57 per cent of their spending across domains, except in the Kathmandu Valley, where their share of food expenditure is low at 50 per cent.

Across all rural domains, the average share of food spending among the richest 20 per cent of the population is about half of the total consumption expenditure.

This share is much higher compared to the top quintile in the Kathmandu Valley, whose average share of spending on food is only 28 per cent.

The survey found that the construction of the minimum caloric requirement in 2022/23, is estimated at 2,236 kilocalories per person per day, which is marginally higher than the 2,220 kcal per day used for the old poverty line.

Addressing the function, NPC vice chairman Dr. Shrestha said that the rate of poverty line could not decline as expected due to natural disasters, including earthquakes and others, and the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic.

He, however, said that the findings of the survey would be fruitful to formulate and implement the policies and programmes to reduce the rate of poverty in the coming days.

Man arrested on charge of murder in Dhapasi

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 12

The police have arrested a man on the charge of murdering 23-year-old Dipesh Khadka in Dhapasi, Kathmandu.

Surprisingly, the man was the room partner of murdered Khadka.

The arrested person has been identified as Bikash Thapa Magar, 18, a permanent resident of Likhu Rural Municipality-3 of Okhaldhunga.

Khadka, who was a plumber by profession brought Bikash Thapa Magar to Kathmandu from his district for a job as a plumber.

After recovering the body in a zinc-roofed shed in Dhapasi, Tokha Municipality-6, Kathmandu, on Saturday (February 10), the police had started investigating the incident.

Senior Superintendent of Police (SSP) and Chief of Kathmandu District Police Range, Bhupendra Khatri said that while investigating it was revealed Khadka was killed by his room-partner Bikash Thapa Magar.

According to the police, Dipesh brought Bikash from the village to help him in plumbing.

SSP Khatri said that Dipesh brought the accused to Kathmandu saying that he would pay him Rs. 15,000 a month.

Bikash was asking for money after not getting money for more than two-and-a-half months after he came to Kathmandu. However, Dipesh did not give the money as they lived together in Dinesh Khadka's house in Dhapasi.

Kathmandu's SSP Khatri said, "It seems that there was a dispute after the accused repeatedly said that he should take about Rs. 50,000 from Dipesh."

According to the officers involved in the investigation, the deceased was a marijuana user. When he was consuming marijuana, Bikash hit him on the head with a hammer from behind.

In the press conference held on Monday, SSP Khatri said that he was killed by continuously hitting him with a hammer. Khatri said, "It seems that he hit him with the hammer until the hammer's handle broke."

After the murder, Bikash left the house taking the key of the door with him. When the door was not opened for two days, locals informed the police and Dipesh was found dead.

Bikash, who is said to have killed him, has told the investigating officers that he had no remorse after killing him.

An officer involved in the investigation said that the accused readily and easily confessed to the crime.

Government of Nepal
Ministry of Health & Population
Department of Health Services
Management Division
Pachali, Teku, Kathmandu, Nepal

Notice of Intention to Award

Date of Notice: 13 February 2024

Pursuant to clause 27(2) and 47(3) of Public Procurement Act 2063, this is to notify all the bidders that the following substantially responsive lowest bidders have been selected to award the contract as per the Invitation for Bids published on Rising Nepal and DOHS intends to award the contract to the same.

S. N.	IFB No.	Item	Name of Successful Bidder	Price bid opened date	Total Amount
1	DOHS/G/ICB-21/FWD/2080-81	Procurement of Vitamin A Capsule	Renata Limited Plot 1, Milk Vita Road, Sector 7, Mirpur, Dhaka	2 February 2024	USD 64,750.00 CIP

President honours singer Menuka



PHOTO: SAGAR BASNET/TRN

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 12

President Ramchandra Paudel honoured differently-abled singer Menuka Poudel at a ceremony organised at the President's Office in Shital Niwas on Monday.

Honouring singer Poudel, the President said that Menuka's hard work and ability made all Nepali people proud.

The President urged her to continue practising music and to further advance in her musical career.

During the programme, she also sang a few patriotic songs. She said, "I am happy to make the country proud in the international arena."

She expressed her happiness for the honour of the President, and added that the honour motivated her to excel and contribute to music.

Singer Poudel returned to Nepal last week after being eliminated from the popular Indian singing reality show Indian Idol 14, securing a position in top-10.

During her journey on Indian Idol, she mesmerised judges, guests and the Indian audience with her soulful voice.

Not only did she enthral the Indian audience, but she also received offers for playback singing in Hindi films.

Recently, she was roped in for 'Karmaa Meets Kismet', another project as a playback singer.

She had earlier made her debut as a playback singer in the South Indian film 'Salaar'.

Poudel is set to perform in various countries, including America, the UK, Mauritius and South Africa, with the Indian Idol team.

Staging of 'Gangalal' extended

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 12



The play 'Gangalal,' directed and written by Che Shankar, has extended its staging period at Shilpee Theatre in Battisputli.

Earlier, the play was to be staged only until Monday. Its staging had begun on February 2.

However, the director and writer of the play said that the date was extended as the viewers to enjoy the play were gradually increasing.

Collaboratively produced with Gangalal Foundation and Garden Theatre, the play delves into the life of Martyr Gangalal Shrestha, portraying him not only as a revolutionary figure but also as a multifaceted human being.

Che Shankar, emphasising a nuanced portrayal of Martyr Gangalal, has constructed the narrative around historical events from 1991 BS to 1997 BS, intertwining them with the martyr's life experiences.

The play also narrates about Martyrs Shukraraj Shastri, Dharma Bhakta Mathema, Dashrath Chand and Tank Prasad Acharya, Ganeshman Singh and poet Siddhicharan Shrestha, offering a diverse perspectives for students, teachers, politicians, writers, and artists.

The play was first staged at Rastriya Naachghar on January 30, coinciding with Martyr's Day.

Nirbhik Bhattarai, Shaku Shah, Inara Banu, Sandip Dangol, Pradeep Kumar Chaudhary, Niraj Dahal, Bishwas Manandhar and others have done the play.

Musical arrangements were helmed by Utsav Budhathoki while Rijan Maharjan and Abhishek BK served as the sound designer.

The director also mentioned that in response to its educational relevance, the play would continue to be staged at various times, accommodating schoolchildren and educational institutions upon request.

Now, the play will be staged till February 17.

Nepali poetry released in New Delhi World Book Fair



BY A STAFF REPORTER
New Delhi, Feb. 12

Nepali poet Amar Akash's first poetry collection 'Tungana' was released on Sunday amid a programme on the second day of the World Book Fair 2024 being held in New Delhi, India.

Odiya poet and former Ambassador Amarendra Khatua, Himalayan poet Yuyutsu Sharma, poet and historian Radha Chakraborty and a dozen other Indian poets were present at the event where Pratik Magazine's Australia issue was also launched.

In the multilingual poetry reading held at the fair, poets recited their poems in Tamil, Hindi, English, Nepali and other languages. At the event, Yuyutsu Sharma recited the title poem Tungana in English.

Other poets including Manoj Krishnan, Mandira Ghosh, Usha Muju Munsi, Rachana Joshi, Sanjula Sharma, Poonam Suri, Rumki Vasu, Swati Ramble Sharma, Priyasha Mohanty, Eval Bharti and others also recited poems.

Shreejana Bhandari, Director of White Lotus Book Shop Kathmandu, concluded the programme by stating such events would strengthen the cultural exchange between different countries and help Nepali poets be known around the world.

CHRISTOPHER NOLAN WINS TOP DIRECTORS GUILD AWARD FOR OPPENHEIMER

AP
London Feb. 12

Christopher Nolan was awarded the top prize at the Directors Guild Awards for "Oppenheimer" Saturday, solidifying his front-runner status for next month's Oscars.

Other winners at the untelevised ceremony in Los Angeles included Celine Song, for first time directorial achievement for her romantic drama "Past Lives," and Mstyslav Chernov for the documentary " 20 Days in Mariupol, " a joint project between The Associated Press and PBS "Frontline."

The Directors Guild of America also recognizes achievements in scripted and non-scripted television, with the drama series prize going to Peter Hoar for "The Last of Us" episode "Long, Long Time," and the comedy trophy for Christopher Storer for the "Fishes" episode of "The Bear."

The DGA award is a first for Nolan who had been nominated for the same award four times previously, for "Memento," "The Dark Knight," "Inception" and "Dunkirk."

Beyoncé drops new songs 'Texas Hold 'Em' and '16 Carriages

AP
Los Angeles, Feb. 12

Beyoncé is back with two new country tracks — "Texas Hold 'Em" and "16 Carriages."

After a Verizon commercial starring Beyoncé aired during the Super Bowl ended with the superstar saying "They ready, drop the new music," the question became — was she serious? Later, a cryptic Instagram video with country iconography appeared on her page, teasing "act ii" on March 29. (Beyoncé's 2022 album "Renaissance" is frequently referred to as "Act I: Renaissance.")

At the end of the clip, a plucky acoustic guitar riff plays, and Bey's unmistakable voice kicks in. She sings, "This ain't Texas / Ain't no hold 'em / So lay your cards down down down," in a Southern twang.

It appears on her official website as well. Under the "music" tab, two titles were listed — "Texas Hold 'Em" and "16 Carriages," which later appeared as full songs on Tidal, YouTube and Spotify. The first is an uptempo country and western stomp. She sings in the earworm bridge: "And I'll be damned if I cannot dance with you / Come pour some liquor on me honey, too / It's a real-life boogie, and a real life hoedown / Don't be a bitch, come take it to the floor now."

The second, "16 Carriages" is a soulful slow-burn with ascendent organs and steel guitar, Beyoncé singing an ode to hard work and legacy. "I miss my kids / Overworked and overwhelmed," she sings in the pre-chorus. "Still workin' on my life, you know / Only God knows, only God knows." A quick examination of the credits shows she may be working closely with Tony! Toni! Toné! 's Raphael Saadiq.



In a mostly fictional Verizon commercial that aired moments before the Instagram announcement, Beyoncé tried several tactics to try to break the internet.

With former "Veep" star Tony Hale playing an adviser, she opens a "Lemonade" stand, releases a saxophone album called "Let's Get Saxy," does her own version of the "Barbie" movie called "BarBey," sells a cyborg version of herself, runs for "Beyoncé of the United States," and blasts off in a rocket to become the first woman in space. After Hale tells her none of that worked, she says on the space ship intercom, "OK, Bey ready: drop the new music."

Beyoncé was also shown soon on the telecast soon after at Allegiant Stadium watching the Super Bowl with husband Jay-Z.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

Aries: You may currently feel like you need to prove yourself to your peers. As competitive Mars races into your social sector, every little thing seems to be a comparison or a contest!

Taurus: Pushing for an ambitious goal is encouraged by the universe. Perhaps some of your motivation comes from a personal trauma that you normally don't share, and you're not required to tell the whole story to your peers.

Gemini: Perceived judgment from your peers may currently stress you out. It might seem to focus on you having the wrong political or spiritual views. In truth, there's potentially nothing you could do to make these people happy.

Cancer: Asserting yourself may presently provoke a disapproving response from an authority figure. While individualistic Mars charges into your 8th House of Boundaries, you're probably looking to increase the amount of freedom in your life.

Leo: You may want closeness now, but it's probably hard for anyone to live up to your standards! You've possibly developed rigid ideas about the way relationships should look in order to protect yourself.

Virgo: You're presently capable of getting a lot of work done. Although you might have a lot of pride in what you accomplish as determined Mars barrels into your responsible 6th house, perhaps you're also a little resentful that you have to do everything yourself.

Libra: You could presently be motivated to pursue what makes you happy. However, receiving a discouraging reaction from someone else might cause you concern about proceeding further.

Scorpio: Taking charge in your domestic environment could currently ruffle a few feathers. As ambitious Mars bursts into your 4th House of Home, you can see clearly what needs to be done.

Sagittarius: Saying your piece could seem critical now. As the sensitive Moon meets suffering Chiron in your expressive 5th house, it's possible that you're drawn to tell others about an incident where you were harmed in some way.

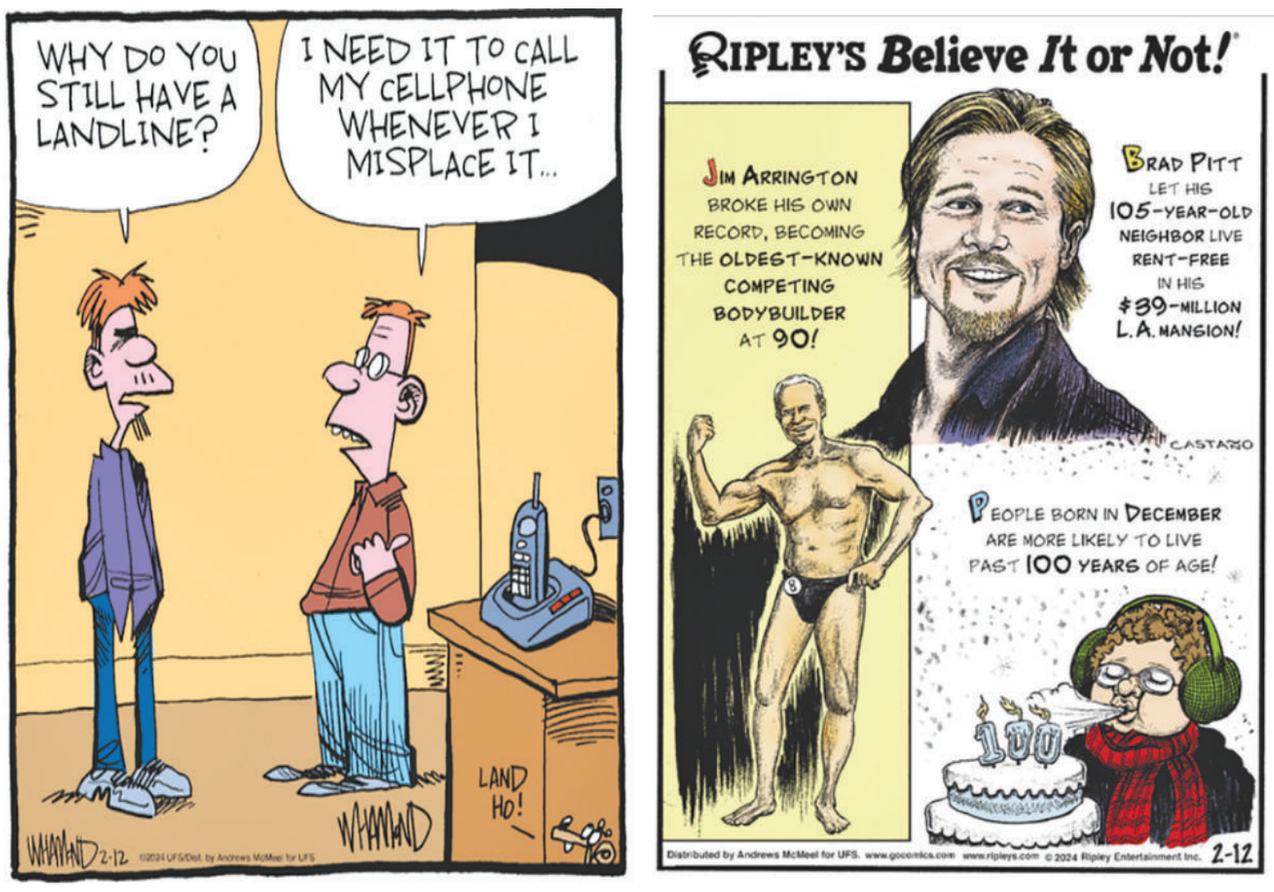
Capricorn: Making more money could currently be a high priority for you. While the sentimental Moon commiserates with wounded Chiron in your 4th House of Roots, you're increasingly motivated by a desire.

Aquarius: You're a force to reckon with today! As potent Mars powers into your sign, you could serve as a lightning rod for all kinds of conflict. When provoked, you might talk back in an especially cutting way.

Pisces: A subversive approach might seem necessary in the moment. While pushy Mars sneaks into your 12th House of Secrets, you may be tempted to take action behind someone else's back.

CARTOON

gocomics.com



Anil, Bhim guide Nepal to clean sweep victory over Canada with record tons



PHOTO: BIKASH/TRN

BY PRAMOD JOSHI
Kathmandu, Feb. 12

Having already won the Bilateral Series with two consecutive wins against Canada, Nepal was playing the third match for a clean sweep in Kathmandu on Monday. A maiden century each from Opener Anil Sah and Number three batter Bhim Sarki made it possible as Nepal notched up a nine-wicket victory over Canada. On a day when Anil and Bhim put on a record partnership with two centuries in the same innings, Nepal achieved its first historic clean sweep on home soil. Nepal claimed the first match by seven runs and the second match by seven wickets.

Earlier, Nepal had not won all the matches in the two bilateral series held at home grounds. Earlier Nepal lost to Papua New Guinea (PNG) by 2-0 and won the series against the United Arab Emirates 2-1 held in 2022.

With the series whitewash, Nepal also sends a message to the upcoming ICC World Cup Cricket League 2 triangular series set to start on February 15 in Kathmandu.

Put on to bat first at TU Cricket Ground, Canada posted a medium score of 232 runs losing eight wickets in 50 overs.

Nepal rode on the record partnership from Anil and Bhim to easily chase the victory with 234 runs with 33 balls to spare.

Record partnership

After Nepal lost the first wicket of Kushal Bhurtel (13 runs off 14 balls) in the 4.5 overs, it was all about Anil and Bhim. They went on to put up the most substantial partnership for any wicket for Nepal in the ODI, scoring 189 runs. It was also a record partnership for the second wicket for Nepal.

They surpassed the previous records set by Kushal Bhurtel and Aasif Sheikh during the first-wicket partnership against Zimbabwe (179 runs) and Gyanendra Malla and Aasif Sheikh during the second-wicket partnership against Namibia (139 runs).

Anil, the top scorer in the men's PM Cup, made his comeback to the national squad after 2022 in style. He scored a maiden century and two consecutive half-centuries, which would surely make him a strong contender during team selection. He smashed his first ODI fifty on Saturday and bettered it today by scoring his first ODI hundred off 116 balls. He remained unbeaten with 112 runs off 124 balls, which included 12 boundaries and two sixes. Anil smashed Uday Bhagwan for a six to seal the match for Nepal in 44.3 overs.

Bhim also reached his first hundred-run milestone off 129 balls. He smacked 11 fours and one six in his knock of 101 runs off 129 balls.

It is also the first time that two Nepali batters have scored a hundred in one ODI match, making it a historic moment for Nepal. This match also saw Nepal's seventh and eighth centuries in ODIs.

Nepal started their batting with an additional five runs, which they received as a penalty after Canada's captain, Saad Bin Zafar, walked on the pitch twice. Dillon Heyliger was the only wicket-taker for Canada.

Debutant Hemant shines

A debutant Hemant Dhami took three wickets, limiting Canada to a moderate score after Nepal won the toss and chose to field first.

Hemant, a medium pacer, took his first wicket in the second over of his spell by making Aaron Johnson (4) catch out by Dev Khanal at third.

However, Navneet Dhaliwal (50) and Srimantha Wijeyeratne (22) managed to put up a fight with a partnership of 48 runs for the second wicket.

Aakash Chand broke the partnership by chipping Srimantha to the hand of captain Rohit Paudel in the 14th over.

Nicholas Kirton (3) returned to the dugout as the third wicket in 18.1 overs after trying to hit Kushal Malla for big.

Opener Navneet kept the run ticking for the tourists as he completed his half-century off 81 balls. His patience batting, however, came to an end on the next ball as his shot to Lalit Rajbanshi went straight into the hand of Aakash Chand at long off in the 27th over.

Harsh Thaker (29) put on a 31-run partnership with Nikhil Dutta for the fifth wicket. After Kushal trapped Harsh lbw, Nikhil paired with Shreyas Movva (25) to add 54 runs for the sixth wicket.

Debutant Hemant came in a rescue for the home making Shreyas catch out by Kushal Bhurtel in the 45.4 overs.

Nikhil steered Canada past a double hundred but was run out in the 47.5 overs with 213/7 on the scoreboard. He clubbed one six and two fours in his knock of 62-ball 45. Captain Saad took charge of the remaining overs adding not out 31 runs that included two maximums and three fours.

In-between, Hemant bagged his third wicket making Dillon (4) caught by Aarif Sheikh at deep point in the 48.3 overs.

Nepal's pick of the bowler Hemant conceded 49 runs from his eight-over spell. Kushal finished with 2-38 while Lalit and Aakash dismissed one batter each.

NATIONAL SQUAD NAMED FOR WAFF CHAMPIONSHIP



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 12

The All Nepal Football Association has announced the 23-member women's national team that will be competing in the WAFF Championship-2024 in Saudi Arabia, starting on February 19. Head Coach Rajendra Tamang named the squad on Monday. He included forward Chandra Bhandari and midfielder Saraswoti Hamal in the team for the first time. Additionally, the coach has also named forward Sabitra Bhandari, who is currently playing in the top-tier league in France.

Six players from the Indian Women's Football League have also been called up to join the squad for the championship. Captain and goalkeeper Anjila Tumbapo Subba and Gita Rana both play for Sethu FC, Rashmi Ghishig and Amrita Jaisi for Odisha FC, and Preeti Rai and Dipa Shahi for Kickstart FC.

Nepal has been grouped with Palestine, Syria, and Iraq in the championship, while the other group consists of Saudi Arabia, Gwan, Lebanon, and Jordan. Nepal will begin its campaign at WAFF by playing against Syria on February 20, followed by Iraq on February 22, and Palestine on February 24. The top two teams from the group will advance to the semifinals of the tournament.

Squad: (Gks) Anjila Tumbapo Subba, Usha Nath, Anjana Rana Magar; (Dfds) Gita Rana, Amrita Jaisi, Hira Kumari Bhujel, Bimala Bk, Nisha thokar, Samiksha Ghimire, Puja Rana, Sabina Chaudhary; (Mfds) Anita Basnet, Amisha Karki, Anita KC, Preeti Rai, Dipa Shahi, Bimala Chaudhary, Chandra Bhandari, Saraswoti Hamal and (Fwds) Sabitra Bhandari, Rekha Paudel, Rashmi Kumari Ghising and Sabita Rana Magar.

SNIPPETS

Nasir, Gaurika set National Records

Kathmandu (TRN): Nasir Yahya Hussain and Gaurika Singh have set new national records in the World Aquatics Championships in Qatar. Nasir set a new record in the 200-meter freestyle event, improving his previous record time by 0.87 seconds and finishing in 1 minute 56.39 seconds at the championship. His previous record of 1 minute 57.26 seconds was set during the World Aquatics Championship held in Japan's Fukoka city. Ashok Rana Bajracharya, the president of Nepal Swimming Association, confirmed the record. Nasir also set a new national mark in the 400-meter freestyle event, finishing in 4 minutes 5.65 seconds on Sunday. Similarly, Gaurika Singh broke her own national record in the 100-meter backstroke event, finishing in 1 minute 5.47 seconds. She bettered her previous record of 1 minute 6.80 seconds set at the championship held in Fukoka, Japan, in 2023.

Australia wins under-19 World Cup

Benoni (AP): Harjas Singh top-scored with 55 runs as Australia finished unbeaten to win the men's under-19 World Cup after beating India by 79 runs in the final on Sunday. After electing to bat, Australia scored 253-7 in its 50 overs. The Australians then bowled India out for 174 with player of the match Mahli Beardman (3-15) and Raf MacMillan (3-43) the leading bowlers for the winners. Opener Ardah Singh led India with 47 runs while Murugan Abhishek added 42. Raj Limbani took 3-38 to lead the Indian bowlers. It was Australia's fourth under-19 men's World Cup victory and its first since 2010 when current internationals Mitch Marsh and Josh Hazlewood were members of the squad.

Marathon world record-holder Kelvin killed in car crash

AFP
Nairobi, Feb. 12



Marathon world record-holder and Paris Olympic favourite Kelvin Kiptum died in a car crash in western Kenya, police said Monday.

The 24-year-old was driving from Kaptagat to Eldoret around 11 pm (2000 GMT) on Sunday when the car rolled, killing the young sensation and his Rwandan coach Gervais Hakizimana.

"The car had three occupants, two died on the spot, while one was taken to hospital. The two are Kiptum and his coach," said Peter Mulinge, police commander for Elgeyo Marakwet County in western Kenya where the accident occurred.

"It is Kiptum who was driving heading to Eldoret and the vehicle lost control and rolled, killing the two on the spot. A female passenger sustained injuries and has been rushed to hospital," he told reporters.

Kiptum exploded onto the marathon scene when he ran a world record 2:00:35 in Chicago in October, taking 34 seconds off fellow Kenyan Eliud Kipchoge's previous record.

He was just 23 years old at the time, and competing in only his third marathon.

Kiptum also won his other two efforts, in his debut in Valencia in 2022 and a follow-up in London the following year.

The Kenyan had announced he would attempt to become the first man to run an official marathon under the two-hour mark in Rotterdam on April 14.

He was the overwhelming favourite for the Paris 2024 Summer Olympics.

World Athletics remembered Kiptum as "one of the most exciting new prospects to emerge in road running in recent years".

"We are shocked and deeply saddened to learn of the devastating loss of Kelvin Kiptum and his coach, Gervais Hakizimana," World Athletics President Sebastian Coe said in a statement.

"On behalf of all World Athletics, we send our deepest condolences to their families, friends, teammates and the Kenyan nation."

YAMAL RESCUES RAGGED BARCA

AFP
Barcelona, Feb. 12

Barcelona's 16-year-old starlet Lamine Yamal struck twice to rescue the struggling Catalans a 3-3 draw against Granada in La Liga on Sunday.

Xavi Hernandez's side, third, shared the spoils with their relegation-battling opponents, 19th, after a thrilling battle at the Olympic Stadium, but now trail leaders Real Madrid by 10 points.

Los Blancos thrashed second-place Girona 4-0 on Saturday to move five points clear at the top and take full control of the title race.

Earlier Atletico Madrid's faint hopes of challenging for La Liga deflated further with a 1-0 defeat by Sevilla on Sunday.

Youngster Yamal sent Barcelona ahead but Granada battled back with goals from Ricard Sanchez and on-loan Manchester United winger Facundo Pellistri.

WEATHER

Tuesday

Sunrise at 6:43 am, Sunset at 5:53 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Tuesday)

Partly to generally cloudy throughout the country.. Light rain is likely to occur at one or two places of hilly regions of the country. Chances of light snowfall at a few places of the high hilly and mountainous region of the country.

Expected Temp.: 22-24 Rain Probability: 0%

Monday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dipayal	25.2	4.1	0.0
Dadeldhura	18.0	4.4	0.0
Dhangadi	26.4	8.5	0.0
Birendranagar	25.3	6.9	0.0
Nepalgunj	27.3	9.8	0.0
Jumla	17.5	-4.9	0.0
Ghorahi	24.7	8.5	0.0
Pokhara	23.5	8.3	0.0
Bhairahawa	26.5	7.7	0.0
Simara	26.7	8.5	0.0
Kathmandu	22.4	5.2	0.0
Okhaldhunga	20.6	8.2	0.0
Taplejung	18.7	5.5	0.0
Dhankuta	24.2	8.5	0.0
Biratnagar	27.8	6.9	0.0
Jomsom	12.1	-2.0	0.0*
Dharan	28.0	12.3	0.0*
Lumle	18.5	6.0	0.0*
Janakpur	28.4	8.0	0.0*
Jiri	16.4	-0.8	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES
February 13, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.51	Rs. 133.11
Euro	1	Rs. 142.71	Rs. 143.36
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 167.19	Rs. 167.94
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 151.40	Rs. 152.08
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 86.40	Rs. 86.79
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.38	Rs. 98.83
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 98.54	Rs.98.98
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 8.89	Rs. 8.93
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.42	Rs. 18.50
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.34	Rs. 35.50
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.34	Rs. 36.50
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.69	Rs. 3.71
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.08	Rs. 36.24
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 27.81	Rs. 27.93
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.97	Rs. 10.01
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.71	Rs. 12.76
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.14	Rs. 19.23
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.94	Rs. 17.02
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 430.42	Rs. 432.37
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.51	Rs. 353.10

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

Ivory Coast wins third Africa Cup of

AP
Abidjan, Feb. 12



Sébastien Haller scored late to lead host nation Ivory Coast to a remarkable Africa Cup of Nations title with a 2-1 victory over Nigeria in the final on Sunday. Haller fired in from close range in the 81st minute to complete the turnaround after Franck Kessié drew the Elephants level in the 62nd.

It was Ivory Coast's third title after wins in 1992 and 2015, both won on penalties. Veteran Ivory Coast midfielder Max Gradel, now 36, was part of the 2015 championship team.

"Representing the national team is everything, and to have brought joy to all Ivorians with what I've done is even more incredible," Gradel said Sunday. "Perhaps I don't realize everything that happened today yet, there are too many things in my head, but I think I'll take some time to realize it.

"The most important thing is that Ivorians are proud of the team and I think they are that tonight. Winning the Africa Cup this evening, there is nothing better, nothing better."

Haller's second goal in as many games after recovering from an ankle injury that kept him out of the group stage completed a personal triumph for the player, just over a year since he returned from cancer treatment.

Nigeria captain William Troost-Ekong had scored in the 38th against the run of play with a header to a corner. The Super Eagles had been outplayed in the first half and really only threatened again in a desperate attempt to equalize after Haller's goal.

Troost-Ekong also scored when the teams last met in the group stage for Nigeria's 1-0 win. That match had been just the start of the Elephants' troubles as Ivory Coast was almost eliminated in its next game. It fired its coach but recorded late comeback wins over defending champion Senegal and Mali in the knockout stage, before Haller fired the team into the final with the winning goal against Congo in the semifinals.

Ivory Coast's unlikely progression through the knockout stage as it overcame setback after setback convinced many devout Ivorians that God was on the team's side.

"It was an extraordinary tournament," said interim coach Emerse Faé, the previous assistant who took over on his 40th birthday.

Nigeria conceded as many goals in the final as it had in all its previous games in the tournament. Coach José Peseiro had banked on a mean defense to earn what would have been the Super Eagles' fourth title.

"We played a fantastic tournament, but today Côte d'Ivoire was better," Peseiro said. The Portuguese coach said the pressure got to his players and commended the home team for showing none.

In the final, Ivory Coast's pressure finally paid off when Kessié's header to Adingra's corner set off a tumult of joy in the 60,000-capacity Alassane Ouattara Stadium. Kessié ran to the corner and raised his hand to his forehead in salute as the sea of orange-clad fans rippled in delight.

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